Operation: Silent Night

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/75561521.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Netossa/Spinnerella (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Catra's Mother (She-Ra), Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Mila Grayskull, Isaac Grayskull, Ember Grayskull, Finn Grayskull, Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Swift Wind | Spirit, Melog (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Wrong Hordak (She-Ra)

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2025-12-10 Completed: 2026-01-14 Words: 36,974 Chapters: 9/9

Operation: Silent Night

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/75561521.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Netossa/Spinnerella (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Catra's Mother (She-Ra), Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Mila Grayskull, Isaac Grayskull, Ember Grayskull, Finn Grayskull, Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Swift Wind | Spirit, Melog (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Wrong Hordak (She-Ra)

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2025-12-10 Completed: 2026-01-14 Words: 36,974 Chapters: 9/9

Operation: Silent Night

by Garlogan10

Summary

Christmas is coming, and the kingdom of Plumeria is preparing to welcome the princesses for a special dinner. Everything seems to be under control for a peaceful celebration… or at least that's what Adora tries to believe. With Catra pregnant, hormonal, and slightly impatient (okay, very impatient), Adora promises that this year's Christmas will be calm, peaceful, and free of confusion.
The mission? Survive until December 25 without any crises, interdimensional drama, accidental explosions, or children setting fire to the castle curtains.
However, when a boy disappears in the middle of a snowstorm, making the search impossible, the perfect Christmas turns into despair.

Notes

Hello, everyone! So, I'm not completely back yet. But I couldn't end the year without at least one little story. It's been a while since I've written anything about Catradora, and it's been even longer since this story got stuck in my head.

At first, it was supposed to be something simple, a normal Christmas special, and before I knew it, I was scouring the entire internet for inspiration, references, and names.

There will be 5 chapters, maybe 6, but I want to end at 5. I thought about focusing on Catra and Adora, but then the chaos of creation set in, and we're off on a freezing adventure with lots of emotion. (At least for me, it's been exciting, I cried a lot writing the final draft).

Anyway, I have a lot to do, I've been feeling so sleepy it feels like my eyes are about to pop out, but most of all, I really

want to start posting again. I love the comments, and I love even more being able to bring you cool stories. I hope you'll continue to follow along.

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1: The Plan

{...}

It's Christmastime in Etheria, and as expected, all the kingdoms are eager to celebrate another peaceful Christmas after years of conflict and isolation.

It had been two years since Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon and the other princesses thought it would be interesting to celebrate each Christmas in a different kingdom. Everyone welcomed the idea, and this year, Christmas will be in Plumeria.

With the end of November approaching, the princesses were already busy planning. It would be the first Christmas in Plumeria, and like other kingdoms, it had its own traditions. Glimmer and Perfuma were the most enthusiastic of the group, coming up with new ideas every day.

While Bow and Scorpia tried to control their wives and their creative minds, Adora faced another dilemma. As soon as the morning meeting ended, Swift Wind was already waiting for the blonde at the castle entrance.

— Good morning, She-Ra! Gee… what's that look on your face? — he asked, holding the blonde's face with his wings and squeezing her cheeks. — Do you have a cold?

Adora moved away from him, running her hand over her face. — No, I just… — She sighed deeply. — I'm worried about Catra. — she explained as she mounted the alicorn.

— You're always worrying too much, Adora. Try to relax for a change, heh! — He commented, flying over the city.

— With my kids? I can only relax when everyone is asleep. And sometimes not even then. — she replied with a short laugh. — But I love those little rascals.

Swift Wind laughed loudly, climbing higher. — You love them so much, you already have another one on the way. Seriously, don't you ever get tired of making mini versions of yourselves?

The blonde could only nod and smile, dismounting from the alicorn as soon as they arrived in front of Grayskull Castle. Adora said goodbye to her friend, who left shortly after, while she headed inside, greeting the guards and staff.

— Morning! — she exclaimed, waving to the men who were putting up decorations. As she walked, Adora was approached by a lady carrying a tray of letters.

— Good morning, Majesty. Important correspondence has arrived from neighboring planets.

— Thanks a lot, Helena. How's your morning going? — Adora opened a letter, using magic to make the words appear so she could read them.

— It's been a pretty… *quiet* morning. — she said, somewhat impressed.

Adora raised an eyebrow as she closed the letter. — Did you say… quiet?

— Yes, but it’s only eleven o’clock, so… — Suddenly, an explosion echoed throughout the castle, startling some new employees; for the older ones, however, it was a familiar sound. Helena smiled and snorted softly. — Correction: an almost quiet morning! — she expressed.

Another woman appeared in the hallway, running towards the two of them, and gave a brief bow, looking at Adora with a nervous expression.

— Majesty, I'm afraid your children have found *another* form of entertainment in the basement.

Adora sighed and rubbed her eyes. — Please leave the letters in my office. I'll check on it later. — she requested gently, patting the woman on the shoulder. She nodded and went off in another direction with the young woman.

Adora went to the garden on the opposite side of the castle, where her children usually play and… well, conduct experiments that almost always put the castle in danger and leave Catra stressed out. However, nothing that She-Ra couldn't solve.

As soon as the blonde opened the door, another explosion shook the sky, and in the middle of the garden were her two children with a box of fireworks. Her eyebrows knitted together in a tense line, and she hurried over to them.

— One, two…!

— Enough! — Adora took the rocket from Isaac's hand, extinguishing the spark with her hand without showing discomfort. — Who authorized this? — she asked seriously, fixing her gaze on Finn and Isaac. Adora sighed as she watched the two accuse each other. — Kids, how many times have I said this… Never take anything without permission! Do you both understand?

The little ones lowered their heads, defeated. — We're sorry, Mom! — They said in unison.

Adora put the rocket back in the box, surprised by how little was left, suggesting that they had already fired almost all of them. She turned back to them with a frown; however, seeing them with their heads down softened the blonde's heart.

— I don't want to spoil your fun, but could you play with something that isn't explosive? — she asked, stroking both their heads.

— We were going to go out for a walk, but Mila didn't want to. — Isaac said, rolling his eyes.

— Where's your sister? — Adora asked, hands on her hips.

— She's making out with her boyfriend behind that tree. — Finn pointed with his thumb, without looking back.

Adora's eyes widened. — What?! — She ran to the spot indicated by her son. And, just as Finn had said, Adora caught Mila kissing her boyfriend. Her eyes drifted downward, where the young man was running his hands up her daughter's waist, and Adora was well aware of where those hands intended to touch. Adora didn't hesitate and grabbed the boy by his shirt, lifting him off the ground effortlessly.

— Ah! H-Hi, Mrs. Grayskull! Long time no see… — He laughed nervously, extending his hand to greet Adora.

The blonde raised an eyebrow, watching the boy's hand. — It's only been three days since I saw you, Sam.

— A long time, huh? — He cringed under the blonde's piercing gaze. However, Mila quickly intervened.

— Mom, put him down. — Mila crossed her arms and stared at her mother, who then released him.

— I thought I told you to take care of your brothers. — Adora adopted a more rigid posture, crossing her arms as well.

— They're fine. They're playing in the garden! — she said, stroking her blond hair.

— Yes, with fireworks! — added Adora.

— Oh, so that's what was in those boxes? — Mila scratched her chin. Adora frowned, staring at her daughter. — Sorry, Mom! I was watching them, but Sam arrived, and we came to talk.

— I know where that conversation was going. — Adora said ironically, looking at Sam. The young man smiled shyly. — Sam, shouldn't you be with your father?

— Yes, I was with him. But we passed a port and there was such a beautiful flower shop that I thought I'd buy some flowers for Mila. — he replied, looking away at his girlfriend, who smiled knowingly. — A-And I brought this for your wife too! — Sam hurriedly said, picking up the bag next to the tree and pulling out a box. — Mila told me that the queen wasn't feeling very well, so I brought her these chocolates.

Adora looked at the box, sighed, and took it. — Thank you for your kindness. — she said. — But seriously, guys. It's not even noon yet. Please, if you're going to do this, do it at night.

— Can we really? — Mila asked with a smile.

— Of course not! — Adora replied promptly, causing her daughter's cheerful smile to disappear. — Sam, please take your boat and come home. Your father must be panicking, thinking he's lost you at sea. — the blonde woman reminded her, shaking her head slightly.

— He did that once, heh… — Sam laughed briefly, putting his backpack on his back. — I'll text you later. — He winked at Mila and headed for where he had left the boat.

Adora looked at her daughter, who was smiling, before meeting her mother's gaze and immediately breaking into a smile.

— What?

— We need to talk. — Adora said, crossing the garden, and saw her other two children climbing the wooden wall she had made for them. — Kids, come here! — she shouted, heading for the door that led to the castle kitchen. Adora waited until all three were inside before entering herself, making sure they were alone.

Mila sat down at the round table, her legs crossed on the chair. Finn and Isaac also sat down, waiting for their mother.

— Why are we here? — Finn asked curiously, looking back and spotting a basket of apples. Leaning his chair back, Finn picked up

two at once and handed one of them to Isaac.

— It's a family meeting. — Adora declared, placing the box of chocolates on a counter and turning to her sons, resting her hands on the chair. Isaac frowned and asked:

— Family meeting… without Mama?

— Yes, son, she's the reason for the gathering. Let's talk about Mom. — Adora said, looking at her three children at the table.

Mila immediately raised her hand. — Oh, then let me start! I thought you would stop at the first daughter. — she said, getting up from her chair and heading for the food table.

Finn raised his hand too. — Second.

And Isaac did the same. — Third.

— Fourth!

— Ah! — Adora was startled by the sudden voice, jumping slightly away from her chair and locking eyes with her daughter. The blonde woman put her hand on her chest and took a deep breath. — Ember, honey, you scared me! — she said, picking up the girl and sitting her down in her chair, sitting down next to her. — All right, kids, I know you must have noticed how your mother is…

— Crying? — Mila asked.

— Angry? — Finn followed.

— Impatient? — Isaac continued.

Adora blinked, shaking her head slightly. — Yes… All of that. — she said, running her hand through her blonde hair. — Well, your mother is going through a difficult time, and she needs our support. So I've decided that everyone is going to behave this month. — declared the blonde woman, looking from one child to the other. They exchanged confused glances.

— And what exactly does that mean…? — Mila ventured to ask.

— Well, dear daughter. What I mean by that is: no sneaking out in the dead of night. — Adora looked at Mila, who just shrugged. — No hanging from high places that put your life at risk. — she said to Finn. — No blowing things up! — she said, looking at Isaac. — And above all, don't let your sister out of your sight!

— Mom? — Mila called her.

— Yes, dear? — she asked, looking at her eldest daughter, who raised her hand and pointed to the door.

— Ember left while you were talking.

Adora rushed out to look for her youngest daughter, while the other siblings waited in the kitchen, taking advantage of the opportunity to "steal" the sweets that were only allowed on specific days.

It didn't take long for Adora to return with her daughter in her arms. So as not to lose her again, she sat down on the chair with Ember on her lap. Adora cleared her throat and continued the meeting.

— Moving on, did you understand what I said? — she asked her children.

— Just one question: are you included in this too? — asked Finn. — Because you usually end up getting involved in galactic crises and making Mom very worried.

The others agreed, staring at Adora seriously. — Yes, son, I'm included. But not just me. — she emphasized. — Your uncles and aunts will also participate in this… — Adora hesitated, searching for a word to replace "rules." — Mission! — she exclaimed. — Yes, it will be a mission. — Adora watched her children's expressions change to something curious and exciting. — I'm going to call it: Operation Silent Night!

— So we're like secret agents?! — Isaac asked, his eyes shining, excited by the idea.

— Exactly! Oh, but don't tell Mom, OK? This is a top-secret mission. — whispered Adora, looking around, further stirring her children's excitement.

On the other hand, Mila was still not convinced. — Am I the only one who thinks this isn't going to end well? — she observed, raising an eyebrow.

— Relax, Mila! — Finn said, clasping his hands together and gesturing with his fingers as if they were a gun. Isaac did the same, leaning his back against Finn's and assuming a serious expression. — With the Grayskull brothers on the case, this Christmas is going to be…

— Bombastic! — Isaac threw his arms up, smiling wider than his face. Adora sighed, smiling subtly, when she noticed an unfamiliar smell.

— Sure, with you two, it's very likely that something will explode. — Mila commented, shaking her head. Adora frowned even more, sniffed, and looked around.

— Do you smell that?

Everyone looked at Adora, when suddenly an explosion shook the walls. Adora acted quickly, using her magic shield to protect her children and dispelling it as soon as the situation calmed down.

The blonde analyzed the hole in the wall behind her and the other wall in front of her. A castle servant raised his head and, through the hole, looked at the table where Adora was with her children. The blonde smiled crookedly and asked:

— Are you okay?

— One hundred percent, Highness! — the man assured her excitedly, despite his pale face and trembling hands.

— Great…! — sighed the blonde, relieved. — Do you think you can fix it before nightfall?

— Of course, Highness! But first, I need to pass out. — said the man, collapsing from the ladder he was standing on.

Adora and the children widened their eyes in concern, until Isaac furrowed his brow and put his hand on his chin.

— Oh, so that's what the orange button did. It set the timer for the rocket's takeoff. — he said as if it were obvious, making his siblings look at him with expressions of even more surprise. — It was Finn who pressed the button! — he quickly accused.

— Change the name to 'Operation: Silent Night – Fatal Chaos." — Mila recited to her mother before leaving the table.

Adora stared at her with her lips slightly parted, turning quickly as another piece of the wall collapsed behind her.

{...}

The rest of the day passed almost peacefully, but it wasn't as if Adora expected anything else. Although she had come to an agreement with her children, she couldn't place such a big responsibility on them. Even though they had agreed to help, Adora needed a plan B in case something didn't go as expected. However… *What could she do to give Catra a perfect Christmas?*

Before opening the bedroom door, Adora took a deep breath. Upon entering, she found Melog at the entrance, lying on the tree in the room (Perfuma and Scorpia had helped build and decorate it). After greeting the magical feline, she walked further inside.

The room was located on the upper floor of the castle and had a balcony where the feline woman and her loyal companion could sunbathe every morning. Catra and Adora also loved to have night picnics there on special occasions.

In addition to a suite, the room also had a large bed, a space for Adora to train and Catra to meditate. A hammock where the feline woman enjoyed moments with her children, whether for serious conversations or when they just wanted their mother's lap.

Adora approached the bed, her arms crossed behind her back, sighed, and stared at all the pillows and cushions piled up, forming a fort.

— You know, I still think it's super cute and funny that you always do this when you're pregnant. — She laughed briefly, moving closer to the bed and leaning over to look inside the fort. — Honey? Did you take a nap there? — She laughed again.

— Look, kiddo, your mom finally lost it, and now she's talking to the pillows. — Catra appeared suddenly, causing the blonde to jump slightly to the side.

— Catra! — she gasped, looking at the bed and then at her wife. — What a scare! I thought you were in there.

Catra rolled her eyes and nudged the blonde out of the way, undoing the pile of pillows she had adopted earlier and lying down again.

— Your son finally allowed me to get out of bed and take a decent shower. — she said, stretching her legs and exhaling, caressing her now considerably larger belly. Adora settled on the edge, close to her wife's belly, and caressed it with a smile.

— You still think it's a boy, but I'm sure it's going to be a girl. I can feel it! — exclaimed the blonde excitedly, bringing her face close to Catra's belly and giving it a peck. Catra's lips curved into a smile, accompanied by a light, ironic sigh.

— Just like you thought Isaac would be a girl, and then we found out he was a boy? Accept defeat, darling. — Catra recited, amused by the blonde's discontented expression.

Since her first pregnancy, Adora had been competing with Catra over the baby's gender. The first time she got it right was with Finn, but then her son stated that he was neither a boy nor a girl, although he didn't mind being called son or daughter.

At first, Adora had a hard time understanding, not because she didn't accept it, but because she didn't know how to refer to Finn. When mentioning him, the blonde always got nervous, fearing that Finn would get upset if she made a mistake and start to hate her.

Finn spent an entire week comforting his mother, assuring her that he wouldn't be angry if she called him son. Adora got used to it over time, and all those days with Finn brought them even closer together.

— I'm convinced it will be a girl! And I was right about Ember! — she said quickly, trying to justify herself.

— You said it would be a boy the first time, and you were wrong. The second time, you said it would be a boy and… Well, let's say we're even. — Catra shifted her body, grimacing slightly, and Adora got up, grabbing another pillow to support her wife's back. — You were wrong about Isaac, but you were right about Ember.

— And I'll be right again! — she declared excitedly, kissing Catra's belly again.

After a while in the shower, Adora got out and went to the wardrobe to choose her usual pajamas. However, she opted for a long-sleeved shirt, as the days were getting colder, and snow was already beginning to cover Etheria.

She went to the bed, where Catra was reading a book, waiting for Adora so they could rest. However, before lying down, Adora remembered the balcony and changed direction, closing the door and curtains, aware that Catra hated being awakened by sunlight invading the room. Taking another look at the place, she marked "x" on her mental list and sighed with satisfaction.

— So… I heard a loud bang this morning. What happened? Did the kids blow something up again? — Catra's voice broke the silence.

The blonde's face froze for a moment, her eyes so wide they almost popped out. She cleared her throat, covered her legs, and leaned against the headboard.

— It was just a *minor* accident… — She tried to avoid looking directly at Catra. — You don't need to worry! — Adora smiled broadly, but Catra just raised an eyebrow and closed the book.

— Honey, all the explosions they cause ***are*** accidental! — she pointed out. — They always plan how to do it, but in the end it goes wrong. So don't ask me not to worry.

Catra turned away, placing the book on the nightstand next to the bed, and looked back at Adora. The blonde's smile disappeared, and she tilted her head back, letting out a long sigh.

— Okay, you're right. — Adora surrendered, sliding onto the bed and laying her head on the pillow. Because of her belly, Catra could no longer sleep on her side, so she slept on her back. And that, in fact, was something Adora loved.

Whenever the blonde woke up in the morning, the first thing she saw when she opened her eyes was Catra's belly. Sometimes Catra would wake up to the sound of Adora's voice talking to the baby, while her child kicked from inside her belly, excited to hear the other mother's voice.

Catra adjusted herself in bed, watching the blonde turn on her side, resting her head on her hand, and began to caress her belly.

— To answer your question, we now have two holes through the kitchen… — she revealed nervously, without looking at Catra, although she could feel the woman's large eyes on her. Catra said nothing, just rubbed her eyes and let out another sigh, accompanied by a short laugh.

— Just another normal day. — she said calmly.

The night passed quietly, with Adora talking to the baby for a while, until Catra shared some news about the book she was reading to her wife. Thus, they continued until they finally fell asleep.

{...}

At Bright Moon Castle, a new meeting had begun, bringing with it new ideas. While everyone talked and exchanged news at the table, Adora sat with her chair slightly turned to the side, looking at the blue sky through the window.

— Adora! — Glimmer called, snapping her fingers in front of her face to bring her back to attention. — Did you hear what we just said? — she asked, raising an eyebrow.

Adora turned her chair back to the table and looked at everyone present with a crooked smile, adjusting herself in her chair.

— Sorry, can you repeat that?

Glimmer smiled warmly and began to explain again. — We're talking about going to Plumeria, organizing the whole party there in person, instead of coming here or having meetings over the phone.

Adora blinked, taking a step back. — Wait… everyone? Like, all of us?

— Of course, Adora. You're She-Ra, you need to be involved in the preparations for the big Christmas dinner! — Bow declared excitedly from across the table. The others agreed, exchanging glances with each other and then turning to the blonde, who was still reluctant.

— Huh… I don't know, guys… — she said, scratching the back of her neck. — As I mentioned, I want to be with Catra and make sure she has a peaceful Christmas.

Scorpia, sitting at the opposite table, joined the conversation. — We know, Adora, and we're on your side. However, a change of scenery could be beneficial for Catra, don't you think?

— Of course! In Plumeria, there are several places where Catra can rest and meditate. She won't participate in any of the planning, and she'll have the kingdom's servants to attend to her if she needs anything. — said Perfuma, with an enthusiastic look.

— And let's be honest, Adora, you need to relax more than Catra. I've never seen you so anxious. — Frosta commented from the end of the table, provoking laughter among the other princesses, who knew the blonde well.

— Soon, Adora will have an entire league of players! — Mermista commented, making everyone laugh again and start teasing the blonde, while congratulating her on another heir.

Adora sighed deeply, understanding their argument, but there was still another issue to consider. She turned to Glimmer and asked:

— What about our children? We can't leave them alone, and if we take them with us, things are likely to get out of control.

Everyone at the table agreed, but Glimmer would not allow that to stop the blonde from accompanying them.

— We can leave them in Bright Moon… — she said to everyone. When the blonde raised her index finger, Glimmer quickly added: — With the nannies and guards taking care of them, of course!

Adora pursed her lips, lowered her hand, and leaned back in her chair again, resting her elbow on the armrest and stroking her chin.

Glimmer sighed, placing her hands on her hips. — Come on, Adora… — She stared at her sister with wide eyes and a sly pout on her lips.

The blonde spun her chair around, looking at the others at the table. Everyone waited, but they had already decided to take her anyway. Knowing she couldn't say "no," all she could do was say…

— All right, let's go to Plumeria!

~ December 21 ~

After a long journey to the kingdom of Plumeria, everyone finally arrived. Catra stepped off the ship with her arm linked with her wife's, heading toward where the other princesses were. When they saw Adora and Catra, the group smiled broadly and rushed to greet them, as well as the new member of the family. Catra had already gotten used to her friends talking to her belly whenever they met her.

Bow and Sea Hawk pulled Adora aside, teasing her about having more than thirty children. Meanwhile, the blonde just joined in the fun, accepting a drink from Mermista. When the conversation time was over, everyone went to their own space to settle in and start working.

— I hope you like it. Catra, I reserved this cabin especially for you! — exclaimed Perfuma, opening the door, entering the place, and turning to the guests with great anticipation.

Catra observed everything carefully. Located deep in the forest, the cabin was usually used by Perfuma for special occasions. The windows were oval-shaped, and the leaves of the trees entered the room, giving it a more natural style. The place also had a kitchen and a common room, as well as a bedroom in the back, ensuring maximum privacy and peace.

Adora dropped her bags on the floor and a smile appeared on her face. She sighed contentedly, looking around the room with pride. Catra had no reason to worry as long as she stayed there. It was far enough away from any possible incidents.

— What do you think, Adora? — Perfuma asked, standing next to the blonde and finding her expression amusing. Adora pressed her

lips together as Catra ventured through the house.

— You're amazing, Perfuma! — Adora suddenly grabbed Perfuma, hugging her tightly and lifting her off the ground. Then she put her back down and began to search the room. — There's no way Catra could feel stressed here. This place is wonderful!

Perfuma crossed her arms, rolling her eyes playfully, happy to have met the blonde's expectations. Certainly, if it weren't for this place, Adora probably wouldn't have calmed down if Catra had been somewhere closer to all the party planning.

The princess said goodbye, allowing the couple to settle in. While Catra rummaged through the kitchen, Adora arranged the bags in the bedroom, leaving the maternity bag next to the bed, containing everything Catra would need in case her water broke. Although the feline woman assured her wife that it wasn't necessary, as there were still a few weeks to go, Adora didn't want to take any chances.

— All set! — announced the blonde as she left the bedroom, closing the sliding door, and walked over to Catra. She threw herself on the sofa next to her wife, kissing her on the lips. — I'll have to leave soon, but I'd much rather stay here with you…!

Catra rolled her eyes at the woman's drama as she took a spoonful of oatmeal. Before meeting up with her friends, Adora got up to get something to eat as well.

{...}

Only two hours had passed and there was already a lot going on. The center of Plumeria would be the party venue. The citizens were already doing things like decorating the tents and trees around them and greeting Adora as she passed by.

Adora went to her friends, and noticing the tension in the air, she wondered if it would have been better to fake a stomachache to stay with Catra.

The princesses couldn't reach a consensus on each one's responsibilities, and realizing that the situation was becoming problematic, Adora took the initiative and distributed the tasks.

— All right. Perfuma, you'll take care of the decorations. — she said, handing a clipboard to the woman. — Entrapta, you'll take care of the lighting. — she said, handing another clipboard to the scientist. Then she turned to Glimmer. — You, sis, will take care of the Christmas show!

The queen frowned, somewhat confused. — Wouldn't it be better if I took care of the decorations? — she asked, looking at the other woman and giving Adora a suggestive glance.

— It's better to leave that to Perfuma. After all, it's her kingdom. — The blonde shrugged, not allowing her sister to protest, turning away. Mermista, leaning on a log, raised her arm and attracted the attention of the others.

— Since you guys are taking care of everything, can I stay with Catra and relax too? — she yawned, scratching her left leg with her right foot.

Adora sighed and turned to the water princess. — Actually, you'll be in charge of Christmas dinner! — Adora said, looking at the clipboard and then passing it to the other.

Mermista stood up, perplexed. — You can't be serious… — she said, raising an eyebrow.

— I am! — confirmed the blonde, flashing a confident smile. The princesses exchanged glances, looking at the clipboards with their respective tasks. When a guard called her, Adora had to leave. Before leaving, she warned them that Scorpia and Bow would be back soon to help them, leaving them alone.

~ Four hours later ~

Scorpia and Adora met on their way back after the blonde managed to drive a Druvok away from the kingdom.

As they approached, Scorpia claimed to have a bad feeling. However, as soon as they stopped walking, they discovered something quite different from what the scorpion had said. While the other princesses went about their tasks quietly, they watched from a distance for five minutes.

Adora sighed contentedly, her hands on her hips. — See? So far, no disasters. — she declared.

Scorpia moved her lips and whistled. — I'm quite surprised, Adora. When we got here, I thought everything could go wrong, but I'm relieved to see that everyone is adapting well.

It didn't take long for Bow to arrive with Swift Wind, leaving some boxes they had brought from Bright Moon. The man looked around and stopped behind Perfuma.

— Wow! Perfuma, this tree is beautiful! I think it's the most beautiful decoration I've ever seen.

Adora froze when she noticed that Glimmer had turned her gaze toward her husband, watching him with slightly wide eyes. The queen, who had been organizing the stage, dropped some cables on the floor and approached them, joining the conversation.

— Bow, what do you think of the stage? Amazing, isn't it? — The queen smiled with effort, took her husband's arm, and pulled him away from the other woman to get a closer look at the stage.

Mermista, who was organizing the table, heard them, dropped everything, and approached them with long strides.

— Hi, Bow! What do you think of my themed table? It will be even more wonderful when all the meals are ready. — she laughed, putting her arm around her friend and pulling him away from Glimmer, leading him toward the tables. — Oh, I'll tell you a secret: the food is turning out simply incredible! How about being my assistant?

Glimmer grunted, approaching them and grabbing her husband's arm again, while Mermista held him on the other side, looking at the queen with a slight frown.

— Excuse me? I think he'd rather help *me*. — Glimmer pulled Bow away, giving Mermista a forced smile. — Why don't you ask your own husband for help? I bet he'd love to!

Mermista also flashed a sly smile. — Although I love my husband, he's not very skilled in the kitchen. However, Bow would be a great assistant, so I think it's better if he stays with me! — she said, pulling Bow, who was looking from one to the other.

— You should pay more attention to your decor, Mermista, because… — Glimmer laughed sarcastically, looking at the tables. — It's not as impressive as mine.

Mermista smiled even more, approaching her and squeezing poor Bow's arm tighter.

— Do you really think your decorations are better?

The two stared at each other defiantly until a slight cough caught their attention, but they didn't look away.

— Girls, let's stop this. — With her usual calm tone, Perfuma placed herself between them as well.

"*Perfect, Perfuma can take care of that,*" reflected the blonde, breathing a sigh of relief that she didn't have to get involved. However, as soon as she looked at Scorpia, Adora frowned, feeling her concern resurface.

— Bow can help me with my decorating, which, modesty aside, is much better. — Perfuma whispered the last part, but not quietly enough to prevent Glimmer and Mermista from slowly turning their heads toward the Plumeria leader.

Scorpia slapped her forehead, already accustomed to her wife's secretive ways, while Adora, open-mouthed, watched the scene,

breaking out in a cold sweat. Entrapta, who was adjusting the lighting, jumped from where she was and landed on their table.

— Are we in competition now? I accept! — Entrapta exclaimed enthusiastically. At that moment, Adora realized she needed to intervene.

— Guys, it's not a competition! It's teamwork! — The blonde grabbed Bow by the shoulders and freed him from the women who were about to tear his arms off. Bow, in tears of gratitude, hugged Adora's waist as the discussion continued.

— Of course, Adora, you're right. However, I just want *my* teamwork to shine brighter. — Perfuma pointed out with an angelic smile.

Glimmer and Mermista snorted, and the four princesses stared at each other defiantly, starting — whether Adora liked it or not — a competition to see who could create the best Christmas decorations.

Serious Glimmer with her concert stage?

Entrapta with her lights and holograms?

Perfuma with her natural decorations?

Or Mermista with her themed Christmas dinner?

Adora could do nothing to stop the four from quickly moving to improve their own areas. Adora, Bow, and Scorpia remained motionless, just watching the chaos slowly unfold.

— Look… At least they're excited. — Scorpia commented, forcing a smile. Adora laughed for a moment, swallowing hard, trying to find a way to put out that fire.

— The table is on fire!

Adora turned to the side, her eyes wide. — Oh, my God… it literally is!

Chapter 2: Decorations and Thunderstorms

Chapter Notes

Hello!
Here we go with another chapter. I hope you enjoy it. If you find any mistakes, please let me know, and I'll make a note of them and fix them after all the chapters have been posted.
If you like my stories, please help me out with your support. There's a link on my Instagram: @10_garlogan.
If you can just share it, that would be wonderful too.
Anyway, that's all for now! <3

{...}

How did we get to this point?

That's what Adora asked herself every second. When she gave up persuading the other princesses to cancel the competition, Adora, Bow, and Scorpia ran back and forth, making sure the situation didn't get even more out of control.

While Adora inspected the kitchen, Scorpia helped Perfuma create a new scent. She was excited, grabbing jars of ingredients and pouring everything into a large pot.

— Honey… why are you doing this? All your flowers already have a lovely scent. — said Scorpia, as she held things for Perfuma, who stirred the pot with a sparkle in her eyes.

She turned to Scorpia, adding another bottle to the pile the woman was already carrying, and gave her a peck on the cheek.

— I know, my dear. But this… — She turned back to the pot. — This will make this Christmas the best ever! And it will definitely outshine the other decorations, heh…

Scorpia raised her eyebrows, looking at Perfuma with some surprise when she realized that she was indeed involved in the

competition.

"*Would Adora mind if I told Catra about Perfuma's competitive side…?*" Scorpia wondered for a moment, letting out a short giggle.

On the other side, Bow used a ladder to climb onto the stage and connected the cables to the backs of the light boxes.

— Bow, remember that each cable has a color. Don't mix anything up! — Glimmer shouted from below as she held the ladder for her husband. He replied with an "Okay," connecting everything, and climbed down, moving the ladder to the next box.

A little further away, in the kitchen, Mermista skillfully manipulated a pan, tossing the spices into the air and making them fall into the pan with ease, leaving Adora speechless. The blonde never imagined that the water princess was so talented in the kitchen.

— Prove it! — Mermista grabbed the blonde's face and, without hesitation, forced a spoonful of an unknown liquid down her throat. Although surprised, Adora swallowed and then widened her eyes.

— Wow! That… that's amazing! — she declared, wiping the corner of her mouth.

Mermista flashed a proud smile, turned back to the pot, and continued stirring, while shaking the frying pan beside it with her other hand.

— Wait until you try my wonderful Christmas special. It will make all the others seem like nothing! — Mermista let out an evil laugh, staring at Adora.

With her arms crossed and a stern look on her face, the blonde exclaimed: — This isn't a competition! — Mermista ignored her, turning back to the stove.

— Sure, sure. Let's not let this divide us, but I still want to be the best! — Once again, she laughed evilly, falling silent and humming some random tune.

Adora rolled her eyes, staring at the cook beside her, who, in turn, relaxed his shoulders, defeated. Adora sighed deeply, shook her head, and left the room.

~ Kingdom of Bright Moon ~

What would be the consequences of leaving several children in a kingdom without parental supervision?

Well…

— One, two, three, all saved! — exclaimed Arrow as he slapped the tree. Suddenly, everyone abandoned their hiding places and ran to where young Arrow was standing. Soon after, Jasper appeared with a frown on her face.

— Oh, that's not fair! — she retorted, dissatisfied.

— You messed up, you're out! — Isaac shouted, making the others laugh, before they resumed their game. The nannies set the huge dining table, leaving the guards to supervise each child in the garden.

While the others had fun in the snow, Finn stayed with Ember, building a snow castle under a tree, until, sensing someone approaching from behind, he turned quickly.

— Hi, Finn! — Flora greeted him, sitting down next to them. Finn blushed slightly and looked away. — Miranda and I are going to the waterfall. Want to come? — she asked, making Finn look her in the eye again as she wiggled her fingers.

— But isn't the waterfall frozen? — Finn asked quietly, and she nodded.

— Well, that's true. However, Miranda said she learned how to do something new and would like to show us.

The words didn't come immediately when he opened his lips. Finn sighed as he watched Ember playing, then looked down at Flora.

— I'd like to… but my mom asked us to look after Ember. And since Isaac is…

— I won! Bow down before me. I am the king! — Isaac shouted from across the garden, standing on top of a snowdrift, sticking a branch in the top with a dirty rag tied to it like a flag.

Suddenly, Jack climbed the mound and attacked Isaac, took the flag, and ran through the garden, followed by the others, starting a snowball fight.

— He's busy. — Finn declared, crouching down to avoid being hit by a snowball.

— Isn't Mila here? — Flora asked, dodging the attacks as she looked around.

— She must be somewhere in the castle with Sam. — Finn picked up Ember and went around the tree to avoid being targeted in the snowball fight. — I can't leave Ember alone, and I doubt she'd want to come with us.

Flora's face saddened a little, she was not willing to give up. She tidied her clothes and looked at Ember, who was trying to pull some dry roots out of the snow to use in her castle.

— Don't worry about it. I'll talk to her. — Flora walked toward little Ember, and realizing her friend's determination, Finn understood that it would be foolish to try to stop her. — Hi, Ember! Finn and I want to go to the waterfall. Do you want to…

— No! — Ember replied abruptly, turning away and continuing to remove the roots from the ground, completely ignoring Flora.

Returning to Finn's side, she simply raised her hand, signaling for her not to say anything. Finn respected her friend's time and waited for her to recover before saying anything.

— That wasn't so bad. At least she answered you. With us, she usually disappears when she doesn't want to go somewhere. — Finn commented, letting out a brief chuckle. — Mom Adora always says she takes after Mom Catra for being so sneaky.

Flora smoothed her hair, let out a long sigh, and smiled. — She's so cute, I can't even stay mad at her. — she said, and Finn agreed. — But how are we going to convince her to come with us?

— Leave it to me! — Miranda appeared unexpectedly, crouched down, grabbed a handful of snow from the ground, shaped it into a ball, and threw it at the others. She wiped her hands on her clothes and then turned to Flora and Finn.

Without explaining her plan, Miranda walked toward Ember, stopping in front of the little girl and placing her hands on her hips.

— Hi, Ember! Want to see something interesting? — she asked with a broad smile.

— Yes! — Ember exclaimed, jumping up and dropping the dry roots as she listened intently to the older girl.

— I can show you, but first we need to go to the waterfall. Shall we go? — asked Miranda, turning toward the trail, but Ember just frowned.

— You're tricking me… — she said, her eyes half-closed. Finn and Flora exchanged glances, shrugged, and got up.

— Me?! — Miranda gasped, feigning surprise. — Look at me, do I look like someone who lies?

The young pirate smiled from ear to ear, making big innocent eyes at little Ember, who stared at her for several minutes.

— Okay! — she agreed.

The three older ones watched little Ember heading toward the trail. Miranda stopped beside Finn and Flora, watching them with a smug expression.

— I told you! Leave it to me and everything will be fine. — she boasted, following Ember.

Flora and Finn looked at each other again, sighing at the same time, and just ran to catch up with the two, with the guards following them the whole time.

~ In Plumeria, December 21 – 11:11 p.m. ~

Adora walked along the path under the night sky when she finally saw the lights of the cabin filtering through the trees. The blonde smiled wearily, but her heart leapt with anxiety to see her wife soon.

As she quickened her pace through the white snow that already covered the ground, a noise caught the blonde's attention, and she quickly turned to the side. The bushes began to move, and Adora heard more footsteps approaching.

Adora frowned, drew her sword, and advanced toward the bushes, cutting through them with ease and clearing a path. However, the blonde was taken by surprise by the presence of Catra's magical feline, who, not realizing it was Adora, was frightened and went into attack mode.

— Hey, hey! Wait, it's me, buddy! — Adora exclaimed hurriedly, managing to get close to him. Melog, still looking red and menacing, sniffed the blonde's hand, recognized her, and returned to his normal state.

Melog frowned and meowed discontentedly. Although she didn't understand what the cat was saying, over the years Adora had learned to interpret him just by distinguishing the different meows and facial expressions he made.

— Sorry, I didn't mean to scare you. — the blonde reiterated, flashing an embarrassed smile. The magical feline yawned, shaking his body to get rid of the snow, and accepted the caress on his head. Suddenly, a new noise alerted them, causing them to quickly turn in the opposite direction.

— Adora? — Catra, with an arched eyebrow, stared at her as she carried a basket of flowers. With a confused expression, Adora approached her wife, letting her guard down.

— Honey, what are you doing here? It's risky to stay out here, and it's starting to get colder! — she claimed, holding the feline woman's hand and leading her to the cabin. However, Catra broke free from Adora's hand and began to stare at her hostilely.

— I'm not some helpless kitten, Adora! — she growled, turning her back on the blonde and walking away. Melog followed her, holding the basket with her head, so her owner could pick up a few more items, even though the snow had already covered almost everything around them.

Adora looked at the cabin a few meters away, then at Catra, taking a deep breath. Cautiously, she approached the woman, reached out, and placed her hand on her shoulder. Catra stared at her for a moment, rolled her eyes, and let out an irritated sigh. She continued picking some berries from the bushes, putting everything in the basket Melog was carrying.

The blonde stared at the berries, wondering how there were still so many despite the snow, until she remembered the obvious. Plumeria was a region abundant in magic, capable of withstanding a variety of climates. Adora blinked, looking for Catra, who had already walked away in another direction.

— Hey, honey… — Adora said gently, approaching Catra and wrapping an arm around her waist. — I'm sorry, I didn't express myself well. The problem is that it's getting late and cold, and that's not good for the baby.

Catra sighed deeply, acknowledging what the blonde was saying. So, without saying anything, she took the blonde's hand and walked beside her to the cabin. Along the way, Catra noticed Adora's restless glances, aware of what the blonde was planning.

— You're not going to carry me, Adora! — she suddenly exclaimed, interrupting the blonde's thoughts, who looked at her with raised eyebrows.

— But…

— No buts! — Catra said seriously. — Besides, walking is good for the baby. Since a certain *person* isn't helping me with my stretching exercises! — Catra squeezed her wife's hand tightly, causing her to wince and let out a low moan of pain.

As they entered the cabin, Adora held the door open for Melog, waiting for the magical feline to clean himself before continuing inside. Adora let out another heavy sigh as she closed the door and watched Catra's movements.

— It's not that I don't want to have sex with you. The thing is… there's a lot going on, and I can't get in the mood, you know? — Adora explained as she took off her coat and boots.

Catra snorted, setting the basket on the table. — And what do you need, huh? Soft music? A sensual dance? — she fired back rudely and sarcastically.

Adora shrugged her shoulders, stopped in front of the table, and stood still. As Catra rummaged through the refrigerator, silence invaded her ears, causing her to sigh deeply. She turned slightly and glanced at the blonde over her shoulder.

— Sorry, I'm being dramatic… — Catra said, closing the refrigerator door and walking to the table with her arms crossed. Suddenly, Adora heard a slight hiss and, looking up, saw Catra trying to hold back her tears.

— Hey, hey, Catra… — Adora ran to her, wrapping her in a hug. — Don't cry, baby. I was wrong. I'm sorry. Please don't cry! — the blonde pleaded, stroking Catra's back. She then carried her to the sofa and settled her down until the woman finally said something.

— I was expecting this phase, I just thought I'd be more ready after so long. But it's still the same! — she complained into her wife's shoulder. Catra hid her face in the blonde's neck, and her sobs became more muffled.

Adora sighed, but instead of speaking, she just hugged Catra tighter and remained silent, allowing the woman to calm down. Melog settled at their feet, turning her color to a more gray and melancholic tone.

After a while, Catra finally pulled away and began to wipe her face. Adora held Catra's hands, touched her cheeks, and offered her the most loving and affectionate smile she could, kissing her forehead.

— I'm sorry, my love. Even though we've been through this before, it still feels like the first time. — She gave a brief laugh, eliciting a forced smile from Catra. — Tomorrow I'll bring you lots of candy. And games, books, whatever you want! — exclaimed the blonde excitedly, wiping a tear from Catra's eye and kissing her on the lips. — I'll try to get there early, so we can enjoy them together.

Catra sniffed softly, nodding her head, and then snuggled even closer into the blonde's arms. Adora talked to the baby and stroked Catra's wavy brown hair. The baby kicked again, more agitated than before, making both mothers excited as they played with their little one.

— I talked to the kids today. Everyone is fine. — Catra announced, watching Adora kiss her belly again before getting up and going to the kitchen.

— Did they do anything mischievous? Did anyone set fire to the curtains? — the blonde asked amusedly as she opened one of the cabinets and took out a plate.

— They didn't do anything. — she replied, rolling her eyes when she heard Adora add, "yet."

The blonde helped herself generously to the food on the table, adding more than she usually ate, aware that Catra, even though she knew she had already had dinner, would probably steal from her plate during the conversation.

— How are the preparations for the party going? — she asked, surprising Adora, who ended up spilling some of the juice she was pouring into the glasses.

Adora turned, taking a deep breath. — Huh… they're going very well! — She laughed quickly, returning to the sofa and placing the glasses on the coffee table, then sat down next to Catra with her plate on her lap.

Melog stretched, opening his mouth in a yawn that revealed his large, lethal fangs. He shook his body and walked over to the food machine. Just another one of Entrapta's impressive inventions. A state-of-the-art portable food machine, capable of changing the flavor of food according to the feline's preference.

During dinner, Adora shared a few things with Catra, omitting some details she thought might worry her. The evening passed quietly, and Catra was surprised to see Adora so eager to exercise as soon as they lay down in bed.

~ In Bright Moon, December 22 – 3:15 a.m. ~

While the soldiers patrolled the castle, the children slept in their rooms. Each of them was exhausted after a full day of playing.

However, there was someone who was not sleeping.

Finn's slow footsteps betrayed the young man's fatigue, but Finn was not sleepy. In fact, there was too much on his mind to get any sleep, so he ended up leaving his room to take a nighttime walk, hoping it would help clear his clouded mind.

However, everything seemed even more confusing with each new hallway. As soon as he took another path, Finn bumped into something and fell to the floor.

— What the… Isaac? — Finn got up, took the flashlight out of his pocket, and aimed it at his younger brother. — Isaac, why are you still awake? — Finn looked around, careful not to be heard.

— Me? What are you doing here? Shouldn't you be in bed too? — Isaac retorted, pointing accusingly at Finn.

Finn rolled his eyes and snorted. — It doesn't matter what I'm doing. Tell me what you're doing.

— I'll tell you if you tell me the truth. — Isaac said, crossing his arms and turning his back. Finn gritted his teeth impatiently, but finally gave in.

— I just wanted to take a walk to… think about how I'm going to solve other things. — Finn confessed, lowering the flashlight and letting out a deep sigh.

Isaac turned back to Finn, noticing his brother's dejected expression. Then he lowered his arms and scratched the back of his neck.

— Well… Since you told me the truth, I'll be honest too. — he assured him, pointing to the door next to them. — I was about to open my present.

— What? You can't do that. We can only open our presents on Christmas Day!

— But I need to look great in the Christmas photos! — Isaac exclaimed, forgetting for a moment that they shouldn't be there, and covering his mouth with both hands. After hearing a noise, they both looked around, but as soon as the sound ceased, they resumed their discussion.

— Isaac, explain this properly, young man! — Finn ordered, pointing the flashlight at him.

— Okay, just get that out of my face! — Isaac warned, covering his eyes. As soon as Finn turned off the flashlight, he sighed with relief. — I always open my presents early, so I can look great in the Christmas photos!

Finn blinked, his lips slightly parted. After a long period of silence, Isaac cleared his throat, approached Finn, and held his wrist to confirm that he was still alive.

— Wait, do you always do that? — Finn asked, returning to reality.

— I started doing it when I found out where they kept the presents. Now I look handsome in all the photos! — he said, pouting his lips and raising his eyebrows in a pose similar to that of the men in romantic TV shows.

Finn tapped his forehead and shook his head. — I don't know if I'm impressed by your boldness or very scared by your cunning.

Suddenly, the two were surprised by another bright light, and to avoid hurting their eyes, they put their hands in front of their faces until the light went out.

— What are you two little rascals up to? — Mila said, lowering the flashlight and holding Ember's hand so she wouldn't run away.

— Us? What are *you* doing? — Finn muttered, disbelief evident in his words.

— I'm taking Ember to the bathroom because someone broke the one in the bedroom! — she explained.

They stared at Isaac, who quickly raised his hands. — I didn't do anything! — he replied, placing his hand on his chin thoughtfully. — At least not in the bathroom.

— Never mind. Isaac, were you going to open your present again? — Mila asked, raising an eyebrow.

— Wait! You knew he does that? — Finn asked, perplexed.

— I found out last year. — she said calmly, her hand on her hip.

Finn closed his eyes, shook his head, and let out a deep sigh. And as silence reigned, Isaac felt Ember's absence, looking around and swaying his body nervously.

— Where's Ember?! — he exclaimed, waving his arms. Finn and Mila looked down and didn't see the little girl next to Mila, which caused the three of them to panic.

The only thing that occurred to them was the fundamental rule that could never be broken. “Don't lose your sister!” Adora's voice echoed among them, further intensifying the tension.

— Here! — Finn called out, opening the door next to them, where the gifts were stored. The three of them poked only part of their bodies inside, checking the perimeter.

— Ember! — Isaac pointed when he saw his sister waving at them from the open window before falling. — No! — He ran and jumped to reach Ember in time, grabbing her by her left foot. — Phew… that was close. — He commented, looking at his sister upside down, enjoying the situation.

Suddenly, Isaac's eyes widened as he noticed that his body was leaning forward, about to fall. Before he could scream, Finn grabbed him by the foot, but that wasn't enough. Mila held them with all her strength as the three remained hanging.

— Huh, Mila? I don't mean to be annoying, but we're going to fall! — Finn shouted in desperation.

— Hang on! — she exclaimed, extending her claws from her feet and hands and digging them into the wall, thus managing to pull the three of them back inside.

After ensuring everyone's safety, Mila quickly closed the window, slid her back down the wall until she settled on the floor, and let out a long sigh. Ember wandered around the room carefree, while her siblings watched her, relieved to see that the little girl was okay.

— Guys…? — Isaac's voice trembled. — W-Where… p-presents…?

Finn and Mila looked in the direction Isaac was pointing — the place where all the Christmas presents should have been was completely empty.

— **NO!**

Isaac's voice shook the entire castle, but Mila, Finn, and Ember quickly silenced him. The three covered their brother's mouth, waiting to see if anyone would come to calm him down, but no one appeared.

Seeing that there was no huge pile of presents, the four began searching the entire room, but found nothing. Isaac became desperate, rolling on the floor while muttering several “no's.” He got up, pacing back and forth.

— Okay, there are no presents here. If there are no presents, there is no gift exchange. And if there are no presents, there is no Christmas! — Isaac exclaimed, pulling his hair.

— Maybe the presents are in another room. — Finn guessed, trying to calm the youngest.

— No way. The presents were here! I saw them myself when they were carrying everything inside. — Mila assured him, her arms crossed.

Everyone remained silent for a while longer, until Isaac, panting, stopped in front of his siblings.

— It's been stolen! — he exclaimed, his hands clenching his cheeks and his eyes wide. — We need to tell our mothers!

— Wait, Isaac. — Finn grabbed him by the collar before he could leave. — Not only is it the middle of the night, but our mothers are already very busy preparing dinner. — Finn said. — And besides, did you forget that Mama Catra can't get stressed out?

Mila stood up, placing her hands on her hips. — Finn is right. We can't burden them any further... — she said, looking around and frowning slightly. — We'll find those presents ourselves!

— How are the four of us going to find **all** the presents? — Finn asked, raising an eyebrow.

The oldest took a moment to think, while Isaac walked around the room, staring at some decorations that must have been from the gifts.

— My little gift... — Isaac whimpered, sniffling slightly, and picked up the bow that should have been tied to his gift. — I didn't even get a chance to enjoy it.

Finn approached and patted his shoulder. — Relax, little brother. We'll find the gifts, and then you can practice your funny faces. — he said, letting out a little laugh.

— Mom says I look cute... — Isaac grumbled, pouting.

Finn sighed, shook his head, and looked at Ember, who responded with a grimace and shook her head, eliciting another chuckle from Finn.

— All right, here's what we'll do. — Mila called them back. — Finn and Isaac, wake everyone up early and meet us in the game room. We'll need everyone's help to find the gifts. — she announced. — After that, we'll split into groups, but I'll explain

that better later. Oh, and don't let the soldiers find out! — she warned, and the three agreed.

Isaac dropped the lasso on the floor and ran to Mila, jumping around her excitedly. — So… are you going to say what I think you're going to say?! — Isaac asked, his eyes wide.

Mila took a deep breath. — Yes, I still can't believe I'm going to say this, but… We're going to save Christmas! — she exclaimed with a heroic pose, making her brother even happier.

~ Plumeria, December 22 – 7:05 a.m. ~

As soon as Bow, Scorpia, and Frosta arrived, Adora moved her body forward, allowing her friends to see the situation with their own eyes, since they didn't believe her when she reported it over the phone.

Bow and Scorpia stood side by side, blinking slowly, as if their brains were trying to update the image.

— What happened? — Scorpia was the first to ask, while Frosta and some servants laughed at the scene.

Adora sighed and crossed her arms. — In short… she was trying to install another tower on top of the tree to connect with the other lights, but she ended up slipping…

They stared at Princess Entrapta, part of her body stuck in the snow, her legs sticking out. Suddenly, the tablet in Bow's hand rang, and he quickly answered it, coming face to face with Entrapta's crumpled face on the other side of the screen.

— She got stuck in this rabbit hole. — Adora finished, looking at Frosta, who approached Entrapta and began taking several photos, calling the others to record the moment as well.

The image on the tablet moved as Entrapta wiped the screen until she could finally look at her friends.

— Hi, everyone! Huh, can you pull me up? I can't get out, and my hair is all tangled, heh…! — she said, laughing briefly.

Adora sighed and, for a moment, turned to attend to some servants who were bringing items from the kitchen for the blonde to evaluate, while alerting her to another emergency.

— Can you please take care of this? — asked the blonde, addressing the others present.

— Sure, Adora. Leave it to us! — declared Bow, raising his arm and closing his hand, giving the blonde a thumbs up.

Adora thanked him and quickly walked away toward the kitchen, leaving Bow and Scorpia to take care of everything.

— Entrapta? We're pulling you up now! — Bow shouted down, watching the princess's legs swing.

— **I can't hear anything!** — Entrapta shouted, her voice muffled by the earth and thick layer of snow. Some servants exchanged worried glances, but Frosta just smiled, took a few more pictures, and said:

— Relax! She's survived worse. — assured the snow princess, as she recorded the exact moment when Bow tried to pull Entrapta and slipped, falling on his butt in the snow.

❄

Upon entering the kitchen, Adora saw Mermista concentrating on her chocolate sculptures, which, according to her, were better the bigger they were.

— Adora! Look, isn't it wonderful?! — Mermista exclaimed, showing off her new sculpture made of white chocolate. Adora stood in front of the sculpture, making a slight grimace. — It's a dragon! And…! — Mermista went to the other side, pulling a lever. — It breathes fire!

The blonde's eyes widened, and the heat from the flames reached her face, exuding the smell of burnt chocolate. The other kitchen staff recoiled with a collective "uhhh," watching Mermista quickly turn off the machine and approach Adora, flashing a wide, awkward smile.

— It shoots fire. — she repeated more quietly, using her water magic to extinguish the fire at the tip of the blonde's hair. — Just for the record, you look *adorable* with that sun-kissed look.

Adora closed her eyes and let out a deep sigh, recovering thanks to her She-Ra powers. The blonde spent a few more minutes watching Mermista before heading to the stage, where Glimmer was.

When she went to the back, Adora froze at the sight of all the things there. She walked cautiously, stepping over large wires and instruments; the band Glimmer had hired had sent all the equipment earlier. Finally, the blonde managed to reach Glimmer.

— I know I've said this before, but I'll say it again. This isn't a competition! — Adora exclaimed, crossing her arms, frowning, and staring seriously at her sister.

Glimmer was organizing more speakers for the show. Before the queen had a chance to speak, Hordak, who was also there, began sneezing profusely, asking permission to wash his face and compose himself. Adora kept her reproachful gaze fixed on Glimmer.

It only took a few seconds of emotional blackmail for the blonde to help with the stage decorations. During that time, Adora began to feel an itch in her nose and a strong urge to sneeze. Besides Glimmer, other people Adora could see were also sneezing.
"*You've got to be kidding me…*"

Chapter 3: When Everything Got Out of Control

Chapter Notes

I swear I tried to make this special, something cute and normal. But everyone needs a little drama, otherwise life gets too boring. So let's move on to more drama!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

{...}

After all the effort to rescue Entrapta from the rabbit hole, the princess was free and quickly got back to work, connecting all the lights to her huge laptop. While Adora was with Glimmer, Bow took the opportunity to take some time off.

— Wow, Entrapta, this is amazing! — Bow gasped, enchanted by the dancing holograms. The scientist removed her welding goggles, picked up the tablet beside her, and entered a new code.

— They do much more than dance, Bow. Check this out! — She pressed a button and showed the man the recent updates.

The holograms moved from their place, performing acrobatics and greeting people as if they were real, surprising everyone. In addition, they performed magic tricks, sang, and told stories to children.

With all attention focused on Entrapta's inventions, the other princesses soon snorted and set off in search of new ideas to add to their own works.

Adora even tried to intervene, but again, her voice went unheard. They were all too involved, and even She-Ra couldn't contain them.

~ At Bright Moon Castle ~

While the guards made their rounds, the nannies chatted distractedly in the kitchen, preparing the children's meal, unaware of the heirs' absence.

As agreed, Mila and Ember were already waiting for their other friends, while the two brothers gathered everyone together. Isaac opened the wide door to the game room, making sure everyone went inside, and before closing it, he quickly scanned the area to confirm that there were no adults nearby.

— Can we find out now why you woke us up in the middle of the night? — Miranda complained, rubbing her eyes and yawning.

— It's ten o'clock. — Sam replied. Everyone gathered in front of Mila, looking sleepy and wishing they were back in bed.

— Okay, I'll be blunt. All the presents… are gone!

Everyone stared at Mila, without immediate reaction. Finn and Isaac exchanged glances with their older sister, and upon hearing the first scream, Isaac instinctively jumped into Finn's lap.

— What do you mean, the presents are gone?! — Jasper asked, now completely awake.

Everyone bombarded Mila with questions, not giving her a chance to respond properly, until Sam intervened, protecting his girlfriend.

— Let Mila speak, or I'll feed you all to Druvok! — he shouted, looking at the younger ones seriously.

They promptly stepped back and adjusted their posture, listening attentively. Mila sighed her thanks to Sam, who kissed her on the cheek before joining the others.

— Yes, the gifts disappeared last night, and we suspect someone stole them. — she said, causing murmurs among the young people.

Then an arm shot up, and everyone looked at Flora. — Huh, shouldn't we tell our parents? — she asked.

— They're already too busy in Plumeria. And if we tell the guards, they'll lock us in the castle, and we won't be able to have any more fun! — Isaac declared, causing everyone to nod in agreement.

— What are we going to do? — asked Arrow, his hand raised as well.

Mila pressed her lips together, and then a mischievous smile appeared on her face. Sam looked at her with raised eyebrows and let out a deep sigh.

— Oh, no… I recognize that look! — he warned, making them look at Mila more closely. Miranda looked back and forth between them and exclaimed:

— I don't know what that face means! Spit it out, woman!

— Well, to make things more interesting and less tense, how about a competition? — she suggested. — The group that finds the gifts first will boss the rest of us around for a week!

— I'm in! — Miranda was the first to say, and then they split up. Sam, Miranda, and Jack stood side by side, staring defiantly at the others. — If you think we're only good in the water, wait and see what we can do on land!

— Exactly! We're going to make you eat dust! — Jack shouted, imitating the roar of a beast, making the others laugh.

Jasper and Arrow weren't far behind. — You'd better give up now. Have you forgotten that I have the ability to teleport? This competition is already in the bag! — said Jasper.

— You're the ones who are going to eat our shiny dust! — exclaimed Arrow, slapping her sister's hand.

Mila smiled, crossed her arms, and looked everyone over. — Very well, very well. So, is everyone ready?

— Wait… — Flora suddenly murmured, catching the others' attention. — I'm an only child. How does that work in this situation? — she asked.

Finn, in a burst of enthusiasm, took a step forward. — I can team up with you! — said the young woman, falling silent as soon as the others began teasing Finn.

— Oh, Finn, you're going to love this, aren't you? — Sam teased, raising an eyebrow.

Finn's cheeks turned red as the young woman fiddled with the button on her jacket, trying to justify herself. — W-what? No way! I just think it's fairer for Jasper and Arrow. R-Right?

They looked at the pair of brothers, who just shrugged.

— Well, if no one objects, then it's decided. — Mila said in a low voice, so the adults couldn't hear. — Let the competition begin!

They left the room quickly, and as they walked down the hallway, Mila remembered one more detail.

— Hey, don't forget. If the guards or nannies ask what we're doing, just say we're… — She hesitated, snapped her fingers, and smiled. — Playing hide and seek!

After dressing warmly, they headed outside by different routes.

✨

Frosta and Adora were organizing the space for the children to play. The snow princess used her magical powers to make slides, on which the children could slide and play safely, as well as swings and an ice rink for skating.

While the two were busy working, Mermista and Glimmer were fighting in the background, throwing snowballs at each other just to annoy each other. They didn't even notice Entrapta quietly approaching, grabbing Glimmer's belongings and quickly disappearing. Mermista laughed at her, but ended up having her new pots and ingredients stolen by Perfuma.

— Hey, girls! Netossa just called. They'll be back from their family outing today. — Bow announced, approaching them, accompanied by Hordak, who was carrying a box of robot parts.

— Oh, great! Finally, we'll all be together for the big supper. — Adora exclaimed enthusiastically. — Hi, Hordak! — She greeted the other. — Did you bring more stuff for Entrapta? — asked the blonde, peeking at the box.

Hordak nodded, bowing slightly to Adora and Frosta. They chatted a little longer before Hordak headed toward Princess Entrapta's work area.

As they continued walking through the kingdom to check on the other decorations and houses, Frosta began to sneeze. Adora frowned, handing a handkerchief to the younger woman, then turned her gaze to the other citizens of the kingdom. They were sneezing too.

— Why is everyone sneezing? — the blonde asked, scratching her head.

— Since I arrived, I've smelled a peculiar odor in the air. — Frosta declared, wiping her nose.

"*So it's not just in my head. That smell… where does it come from?*", the thought lingered in Adora's mind.

~ Kingdom of Bright Moon, December 22 – 2:16 p.m. ~

As the competition continued, Mila decided to take a different route, avoiding being noticed by the guards, and headed for the

trail that leads to the waterfall, encountering only the snow from the night before.

She stopped, put her hands on her hips, and reflected. Suddenly, a suspicious movement in a tree made Mila move forward.

— Hi, Mila! — Isaac suddenly appeared in front of her, making her jump back.

— Isaac! — she exclaimed with a frown.

— Sorry! — the little boy laughed, hanging from the tree branch.

— Did you find anything? — she asked, rubbing her hands together to keep warm.

— Not yet… — Isaac replied, swinging back and forth. — But I made some new friends! — he exclaimed excitedly, pointing upward.

Mila approached her brother, looking in the direction he was pointing, and saw a whole flock of Nyqis. It was then that she realized Isaac was actually using one of the Nyqis' tails as a swing.

— Are you just playing around, or are your new friends going to help you find the presents? — she asked, raising an eyebrow.

— They can help! — Isaac declared. — Mom said Nyqis love to find things!

Mila narrowed her eyes, staring at them intently. — Wonderful. Keep going! — she said with a knowing tone, making the youngest smile back.

— Let's go, guys. Up we go! — exclaimed Isaac, being pulled up into the tree again, disappearing suddenly.

Mila persisted in her search, turning to the area near the castle and smiling innocently when she passed a guard. On the bridge,

Mila spotted Finn staring intently at something. She looked for what her sister might be staring at, until she raised her eyebrows, softening her expression.

Finn was so focused that she didn't notice when Mila stood beside her.

— So? When are you going to ask her out? — Mila asked suddenly, surprising Finn.

— Wh-What?! — Finn shouted, looking around, his cheeks flushed.

— Come on, sis! I know you like Flora. — she said, amused by Finn's reactions.

— It's not like that! I don't…!

Flora's laughter silenced Finn, who once again watched the flower princess as she played with Ember.

Mila leaned her arms on the bridge, watching them too. Finn imitated his sister, sighing deeply and looking down.

— I can't do that. — Finn insisted. — She's my best friend.

— So?

— What if she says she doesn't feel the same way? Not only will I look like a fool, but I'll ruin our friendship. — Finn emphasized, despairing for a moment before looking down again. — And I think hearing a *no* would hurt less than losing her friendship.

Finn lowered his head, shrugged his shoulders, and remained silent for a long time. A light snowfall began to fall, delicately painting the ground.

— Look, the same thing happened to me and Sam. — Mila commented, letting out a muffled giggle.

— Really?

— Sam is my best friend. It was difficult at first, but then we managed to understand each other. — she said with a shy smile.

Finn looked away, thinking. — No way! As the old saying goes, what the eyes don't see, the heart doesn't feel! — she said resolutely, putting his hands in his pockets to resume his search for gifts, but Mila stopped him.

— Wait a minute! Bro, the heart doesn't forget what the eyes have seen. — she said simply.

Finn looked away and frowned. — I think I've heard that somewhere before…

— Heh, yeah. I saw it in a movie once. — Mila said, putting her arm around Finn's shoulders, and they headed in the direction where Ember and Flora were.

— Wouldn't that be plagiarism? — he asked, with a smirk.

— Yeah, I'm risking my neck here to support you. So, ask her out already! — Mila messed up Finn's hair, and they laughed together. — By the way, a leprechaun told me that Flora is looking forward to this request! — Mila whispered in Finn's ear.

Finn's eyes widened slightly, and he froze, while Mila continued on her own, laughing at her sister's expression.

— Wait! What elf? Mila, what elf?! Come back here!

~ Plumeria, 4:05 p.m. ~

Glimmer invited Adora and some citizens to watch the band rehearse — excited to receive compliments. Something Adora clearly saw in the queen's eyes. Looking around, she noticed Perfuma and Scorpia were missing. She hadn't seen the women in a while and was eager to ask Perfuma about the mysterious scent.

— All right, everyone ready? — the queen asked the band. They agreed with an OK. — Great! Let the show, which is really just a rehearsal, begin!

The group starts the performance, and all the lights installed follow the rhythm. The backdrop also moves and shines, thus attracting the attention of the citizens. A larger number of people gather in front of the stage, dancing and singing along with the band.

Adora also gently nods her head, following the rhythm of the drums. However, a sudden chill runs down her spine, causing her to frown.

Behind her, other people are sneezing, and near the holograms, some employees are standing motionless, staring at the lights Entrapta has placed. Adora feels the twinge in her spine again, and then heads to where the people are sneezing.

— Is everyone okay? — she asked, offering them some tissues. (Adora had taken several tissues).

— Yes, Majesty. It's just, I think there's something strange in the air. — said the woman, blowing her nose. The women moved away from the blonde and headed toward Entrapta's lights, and Adora became even more intrigued when the group suddenly stopped and began to look up.

"*But what the…?*" Adora gasped, staring at the situation with great confusion, when suddenly she heard Bow's voice.

— Hey, Adora! The band is amazing, don't you think? — he commented, putting an arm around the blonde's shoulders. — Hey, why are you standing here? — Bow looked for what the blonde must have been looking at.

— Something's wrong. Let's talk to Entrapta. — she said, dragging the man by the arm.

~ In Bright Moon ~

As they walked along the trail, Mila carried Ember on her back; the search for gifts was more difficult than the older sister had anticipated. With the snow getting heavier and the sky getting darker, Mila stopped walking and stared at what should have been the trail, but there was nothing but snow.

— Mila… I'm cold… — said Ember, her lips trembling as she clung even tighter to her sister, trying to keep warm. Mila opened her mouth and saw her breath mingling with the icy wind that was beginning to blow fiercely.

— Me too. — Mila shivered, taking a deep breath. — This was a ridiculous idea. — Let's go back to the castle before we turn into snowmen. — She smiled to reassure Ember. — Isaac! — she shouted, calling out to the other and looking back. Isaac appeared upside down, with the Nyqis holding him. — Let's go home, it's getting dangerous out here. — said, settling Ember on his back and turning around.

— All right! — Isaac replied, climbing back up, and they followed the older girl.

Isaac jumped and swung on the snowy branches while playing with the Nyqis. While they were having fun, Isaac didn't notice that Mila was far ahead.

Suddenly, the pack of Nyqis stopped, their ears moving in unison as they watched the forest to their right. A muffled roar echoed through the trees, so intense that it made the snow vibrate. The Nyqis instantly went on high alert, jumping from side to side in utter desperation.

— Hey! Wait! What are y'all doing?! — Isaac exclaimed, as he was shaken by the agile paws until he slipped. He sank into the snow, leaving a perfect outline of his body. — Ouch… my nose… — he muttered, his voice muffled in the hole, as he tried to get up.

Looking around, Isaac could see nothing but a white sea. The wind, now fierce, howled in his ears. Isaac tried to get up, but a

strong gust hit him and knocked him down again.

He let out a groan of pain, but forced himself to stand, using his arm to protect his face as he fought against the wind. Each step felt heavier than the last.

Isaac was so focused on moving forward that he didn't notice what was behind him. In an instant, the ground disappeared. Isaac slipped and rolled down the slope through the snow, crashing into trees, but didn't stop until he reached the bottom of the ravine.

{...}

Mermista had finished part of the meals, storing everything in climate-controlled rooms specific to each type of food. Before proceeding with other dishes, they still needed to clean all the utensils used.

The water princess rolled up her sleeves and joined the other employees in washing the pots and utensils used to create the sculptures. Mermista looked to the side and saw that there was much more to be cleaned.

— Ugh, why did I decide to use all this? — Mermista complained to herself. Then, the water stopped running from all the taps, leaving the princess frustrated. — You've got to be kidding me! — Mermista exclaimed.

Checking the back of the kitchen, they discovered that the water had frozen in parts of the pipes that carried water to the kitchen. To repair it, they would need to remove the parts to remove the ice, but that would take a long time.

Mermista pondered for a moment, until an idea occurred to her. Upon leaving the kitchen, the princess was lucky enough to run into Frosta — exactly the person she was looking for to implement her idea.

They went to the back, and that's when Frosta was able to identify the problem. The two continued to struggle to get rid of all the ice. Despite both of their powers, it was still difficult to move the large rocks that were blocking the flow of water.

...

Mila was greeted by soldiers and servants as soon as she arrived at the castle. She handed Ember to the nanny and looked around. The castle was more crowded than when they left. She took off her gloves and rubbed her hands together in an attempt to warm up.

— Mila! — Finn called from afar, pushing past a few people to reach his sister.

— Is everyone okay? — Mila asked.

— Yes, we came back before the storm got worse. — Finn reported, looking around. — Even some residents of the kingdom had to take shelter here. All the roads and streets are covered in snow. No one is able to leave.

Flora joined the two, bringing a blanket and hot chocolate for Mila. The flower princess then noticed something different.

— Where's Isaac? — she asked, causing the two sisters to stare at her for a moment before Finn looked away at Mila.

— He's with the Nyqis… — she replied, turning and seeing the animals jumping among the trees outside.

— Mila… Isaac isn't with them. — Finn murmured, and both their hearts began to beat faster.

Finn and Mila stare at each other with wide eyes. Mila drops the mug, and the two siblings run for the exit.

— Hey! You can't leave! — shouted a soldier, blocking their exit, and soon two others appeared to restrain them.

— Our brother is outside! — Finn shouted, struggling to free himself from the guard's grip. Seeing that the two were still trying to leave, the guard blocking their way removed his helmet and placed his hands on their shoulders.

— Kids, listen. I can't let you go out in this storm. We'll find Prince Isaac. But I need you to stay here!

Mila was breathing heavily, looking away from the outside. Noticing the panic in the older girl's eyes, the guard held her face.

— Mila, hey, hey! — He shook her gently, regaining her attention. — Call your mother!

...

Adora and Bow search for Entrapta until they finally find the woman in a hole — stuck again. Hordak and Wrong Hordak were trying to pull her out. Adora felt the chill down her spine again. Quickly transforming into She-Ra, she grabbed Entrapta's legs with one hand and pulled her out of the hole.

— Whoa! — Entrapta laughed upside down before being gently placed on the floor.

— Entrapta, your Christmas lights are doing something weird to people! — Adora said, returning to her normal form. They headed to Entrapta's area and found many other people frozen, their eyes fixed on the lights. — Don't look! — Adora exclaimed, focusing her gaze downward. So they turned their backs to the decorations.

Entrapta sat down on the floor and picked up the computer. Adora crouched down beside her, not understanding anything on the screen. While everyone was focused on Entrapta, they didn't even notice what was happening on stage.

As the band played another song, the drummer suddenly began to smell something burning. He looked around for the source of the smell, but then he started sneezing, losing track of both the burning smell and the rhythm of the music.

The other members looked at him in confusion when, suddenly, a short circuit surprised the bassist. There was another short circuit in the outlets and speakers, and the bright panel behind them flashed several times before going out and causing a fire on stage.

People rushed to help the band, urgently removing them from the stage. Although Glimmer used magic to extinguish the flames, the fire did not stop. The cables connected to the upper speakers were also overloaded, producing a loud noise. One of the suspended speakers came loose, almost hitting the queen, but she managed to teleport away.

Glimmer ran behind the stage, pulling out all the wires she could, but the fire continued to spread. She returned to the front, helping the others.

Meanwhile, Entrapta investigated what could be causing people to freeze whenever they approached the decorative lights she had installed.

— Yikes…! — murmured the engineer, grimacing.

— What's wrong? — Adora asked.

— It's just that… the lights are… kind of hypnotizing them. — she replied to the woman, shrugging her shoulders and flashing a guilty smile.

Adora was stunned, looking at the people and then at Entrapta. — Are you kidding me?! — she shouted, standing up with her hands on her head and pulling at some blonde strands. — Why did you make lights that hypnotize people?

— Actually, this pattern was generated from Catra's baby's heartbeat. — The woman explained, opening a new screen and displaying the pattern of the heartbeat and lights. — The color scheme and rhythm of the lights cause the brain to enter a state of passive visual fascination — the same effect that occurs when we observe a repetitive object or movement. In these situations,

the brain focuses so much on the stimulus that it 'captures' attention and diminishes perception of the surrounding environment.

While Adora looked around, averting her gaze from the lights, searching for Perfuma and Scorpia, Bow crouched down next to Entrapta to check her work.

— Damn it… — murmured the blonde, hurrying toward the two when she spotted them. Adora transformed back into She-Ra and carried them back to their previous location, carefully placing them on the ground. — Guys! Hey, wake up! — Adora waved her hand in front of their faces, gently tapping their cheeks.

— Is it possible to undo this? — asked Bow.

— There is a way… But, aw, it will wipe out my entire pattern. How are you going to win now?

Adora and Bow frowned and exclaimed in unison:

— **Entrapta!**

— My bad, my bad! — exclaimed the princess, receiving help from Hordak to change the code and eliminate the pattern to get people out of the trance. — Shutting everything down now!

As she prepared to press the code shutdown button, a loud explosion startled them and unexpectedly caused Entrapta's entire system to crash, causing a major blackout.

Perfuma and Scorpia awoke from their trance, completely disoriented, but followed the others as they ran toward the fire.

Adora stopped abruptly, staring at the burning stage. — **GLIMMER!**

{…}

The cold wind whispered through the snow-covered trees. Although it had lost some of its intensity, the storm continued to batter the kingdom of Bright Moon.

Amidst the snow, a hand rose, and Isaac emerged again, wiping his face and clothes. The young prince struggled to his feet, his entire body shaking from having been under the snow for so long.

— Hello? — he called, but his voice was lost in the icy wind, causing him to shiver and regret not putting on warmer clothes before leaving the castle.

Isaac then began to walk. Although the snow was above his knees, he persisted in clearing a path with his hands.

— Gosh… Where am I…? All this snow doesn't seem normal. — he muttered, struggling to move his legs.

As he approached the gorge where he had fallen, the trail he had left in the snow began to disappear quickly. Dark clouds began to gather in the sky.

— Mila! Nyqis! — Isaac shouted with all his might, then coughed. He kept his eyes on the top of the ravine, but no one appeared. There was no sign of the animals either.

Isaac looked around for a tall tree, found one, and once again braved the snow to reach it. The tree was so tall that it seemed to pierce the sky. Still, no fear took hold of Isaac — only a determined smile.

— If I climb up there, I'll definitely find out where I am. — He placed his hands on the trunk and prepared to climb. — Good thing — He grabbed a branch, climbed higher, and gasped. —, I didn't sleep through that survival class.

Isaac continued climbing, branch by branch, and when he was about to reach the top, the branch he stepped on broke abruptly. One moment, he was almost at the top; the next, his body collided with the frozen ground.

As he tried to get up, he felt a sharp pain in his leg, and a cry of pain escaped him. Isaac lay motionless, breathing heavily.

— Ouch… that… that *hurts*…! — he muttered through his tears, touching his leg and quickly pulling his hand away in pain.

He crawled until his back was against the tree, but just when he thought that would be enough, another noise invaded his ears. Isaac looked around for the source of the sound, until he was surprised when the ground suddenly gave way, causing him to roll into a tunnel.

He was going fast. The little boy's body kept spinning until he finally came to a stop, sliding down the smooth rocks until he was spat out into a cave.

— Why do I keep falling off things…? — he muttered, lying on the ground, staring at the cave ceiling.

The cave was dimly lit, and the silence was broken only by the sound of water droplets thawing and falling to the ground. Isaac took a deep breath, took a mini flashlight out of his pocket, and illuminated the room.

His face was still wet with tears. Noticing this, the little boy hurriedly leaned against the wall, standing up on one leg, and began to wipe his eyes with the sleeve of his jacket. He directed the flashlight toward what appeared to be a path ahead. Despite the chill at the back of his neck and the fear trying to make him cry again, Isaac didn't let it.

— Come on, Isaac. You're a Grayskull! — he said to himself, sniffling as he leaned on his good leg. The other still throbbed with pain, but he continued, running his hand along the wall for balance and shining the light into the tunnel. — It doesn't look so bad…

Suddenly, a muffled noise echoed in the cave, sharpening his senses. He pointed the flashlight in all directions, his heart racing.

Isaac swallowed hard, gathered his courage, and continued on, avoiding putting weight on his injured leg as he leaned against the wall.

The light from the lantern gradually faded as he searched for a way out of that enigmatic place. However, what the young prince did not know was that he was not *alone.*

Chapter End Notes

Hello again!
So, I'll explain what Nyqis are.

Nyqis are creatures that live in the mountains. Some ancient books in the Etheria library say that Nyqis were playful snow spirits, always mischievous and restless, who roamed the highest peaks, testing the patience of the inhabitants of the earth and keeping the mountains constantly moving. Over time, these spirits took on a more concrete form, becoming the Nyqis.

Others say they are just annoying creatures that live by scaring people and stealing things. Nyqis usually stay in the coldest parts of Etheria, but at times like Christmas, when snow covers everything and the weather intensifies, the Nyqis take the opportunity to venture beyond the icy peaks.

⚠️ LET'S BE CLEAR! All the animals I present in this fic are my own creations, invented by me!
Obviously, I was inspired by other animals to do this, that's no mystery.

Chapter 4: A Chaotic Dinner

Chapter Notes

Hello!
Let's move on to another chapter.
As I mentioned at the beginning of the story, I wanted to finish it in chapter 5, but there are too many drafts that I simply cannot discard. There are also things I need to explain in the story, so I think this story will probably end up with 7 chapters. I believe so. <3

{...}

Adora simply couldn't believe what she was witnessing.

People were running around in despair, an entire stage was engulfed in flames, and the peaceful Christmas she had worked so hard to prioritize... was turning to ashes.

With the wind, small sparks began to scatter throughout the region, like a natural light show — enchanting, but dangerous. Soon they reached Perfuma's tree, which, due to the intense aroma produced by the woman, caused the branches to catch fire even faster, engulfing the tree in a matter of seconds.

Adora forced her mind to come up with a new plan. Looking around carefully, she spotted a large metal box. She ran to it and, using her She-Ra strength, removed it from its place. She filled it with snow, pressed her feet to the ground, and jumped toward the stage.

Flying over the structure, Adora turned the box over, pouring the snow onto the fire. The flames were smothered, leaving only thick smoke. Adora was still in the air when Perfuma made large roots sprout from the ground, helping her gain momentum once again. With one last jump, Adora threw the rest of the snow onto the tree, finally bringing the fire under control.

~ Perfuma and Scorpia's Cabin ~

Catra was watching a Christmas special on television when she was startled by Melog's sudden loud meow. She carefully got up from the sofa, thinking that the cat might be hungry. However, when she saw him change color, she stopped. His fur turned bright red, and his body was completely covered in goose bumps.

Catra furrowed her brow. She was well aware of what this meant. Danger.

— Hey… what's wrong, boy? Why are you so agitated?

Melog continued to meow, scratching at the door with his claws. With his tail raised, he paced back and forth, restless.

Catra held his face firmly, staring at him intently. Suddenly, she realized that her own fur was standing on end. She sighed, looking at her own arm before looking back at the magical feline.

~ Plumeria, December 22 – 7:08 p.m. ~

After the dust settled, everyone was able to breathe a little easier. People moved back and forth, trying to recover some of what they had lost.

Adora approached the princesses. — Is everyone okay? — she asked, placing the metal box back on the ground as she looked around.

— Looks like it's over… — commented Scorpia, carrying some children on her shoulders. She crouched down, allowing the children to climb down and go to their parents, and then everyone turned their attention to the stage and the tree, now covered in snow and completely destroyed.

Glimmer sighed deeply, looking at the stage sadly. Suddenly, everyone heard a loud crash and turned to the opposite side of the stage, where they encountered a huge wave.

— Run! — Adora shouted, pulling some people out of the wave's path.

Scorpia and Perfuma did the same, using plant roots to save the people. The water came with intensity, sweeping away everything in its path. Glimmer used her magic to save more people, teleporting them to high ground as they watched Perfuma's tree and Glimmer's stage being swallowed by the waters.

The queen knelt on the ground, lamenting that all was lost. Bow rushed to comfort his wife, wrapping her in a tight embrace. Adora remained by their side, watching the water finish what the fire had started.

{...}

The path out of the cave became more challenging with every step.

Isaac was exhausted, hungry, and his leg hurt twice as much as when he had fallen from the tree. The pain was becoming unbearable, no matter how much the little boy told himself he couldn't stop.

— Come on… just a little further. Hang in there, Isaac. You're a Grayskull! — He shouted, startled by his own echo, which reverberated off the walls of the vast cave.

He swallowed hard and looked around. Since he began his search for the exit, he had felt a strange sensation of being followed.

A chill that tormented him as much as his injured leg. It was as if that feeling and the pain were fighting a battle inside his body to determine who would control him.

Isaac shook his head, hearing his stomach growl softly. He touched his belly, looking for something edible, but there was nothing but wet rocks.

As he continued along the path, the cave seemed to grow larger and larger. For a moment, Isaac found himself jumping and sliding down the rocks with his friends, as some areas of the place reminded him of an amusement park, full of natural ramps. He laughed to himself, daydreaming.

"*I miss them so much…*", thought the little boy, stopping to rest for a moment. Sitting on the floor, Isaac began to hum a song that his mother, Catra, always sang to them. His voice echoed through the cave, providing a little comfort.

{…}

After all the commotion, the water finally dispersed, and they were able to return to the place where supper was scheduled. However, now there was only broken and soaked debris scattered on the floor. Perfuma's tree had also been affected, but thanks to the water and fire from earlier, the scent the woman had created had been completely washed away from the air.

— Guys!

Everyone turned at the familiar voice, coming face to face with Princess Frosta alongside Mermista. They ran towards the group, but as they got closer, they slowed down, observing the surrounding devastation.

— What happened? Are you two okay? — Scorpia asked, wrapping Frosta in a hug.

— We're fine… but the whole kitchen is flooded. — Mermista replied, running her hand through her hair before letting out a heavy sigh.

Suddenly, Glimmer turned to them with a frown. — Wait… so all this water came from the kitchen? What were you doing? — the queen asked, raising her voice slightly.

As they spoke, Adora walked among the debris, kicking a piece of wood from the stage, putting her hands on her hips, and letting

out a long sigh. The argument in the background grew louder, and the blonde closed her eyes in an attempt to drown out the noise.

— You should thank me. At least the water put out the fire! — Mermista exclaimed, crossing her arms.

— Thank you? You flooded everything! — Glimmer retorted.

— Well, if you had done more research, you would have known that those speakers need to be connected with more robust support cables. That way, you wouldn't have caused the short circuit. — Entrapta commented, her eyes still focused on the tablet.

— And you should have controlled your lights, Entrapta! I was mesmerized by… you know, Etheria for how long! — Perfuma exclaimed, truly irritated, as she lowered the other woman's tablet.

— If it weren't for your Christmas scent, I wouldn't have sneezed and broken the pipe. You're more responsible for this than we are! — Mermista argued, her voice equally loud.

The four stood in a circle as the argument grew worse and worse. Adora tried to concentrate; she was really trying hard to stay calm. However, her limit had been crossed.

— ENOUGH! — She-Ra's voice boomed throughout the room, causing the princesses and everyone in the kingdom to look at the warrior. — You are all responsible! From the beginning, I have been saying that this is not a competition! But did anyone listen to me? No! — she shouted, causing them to look away. — And now, look what happened. Everything has been ruined: the decorations, the food, the children's area!

The princesses looked around, seeing the citizens trying to salvage something from the rubble.

— It's your fault too, Adora.

Everyone turned to the voice that suddenly appeared. Turning around, Adora saw Catra riding on Melog's back. The magical feline lay down, making it easier for his owner to climb down carefully. The blonde's breath caught in her throat as she stared at her wife and then at the surrounding mess.

— Honey, what are you doing here? — she asked, her voice faltering.

Catra raised an eyebrow and crossed her arms. — Please, Adora. Did you really think I wasn't aware of what was going on? — she replied. — The competition, the decorations, everything! I knew from the first day we arrived.

— Wh-what? But… how?

— Bow, Scorpia, and Frosta would call me whenever you weren't around. — Catra explained simply. Still, those words hit Adora like a ton of bricks.

The blonde looked around for the three of them, but they just shrugged. Then Adora stared at them with a betrayed look on her face.

— You are all responsible. — Catra continued, her gaze stern. — Although you turned this into a game, which doesn't surprise me, you all crossed the line. Look around you! — she ordered, and the princesses began to observe their own creations, now clearly realizing how far they had gone. — Is this how we are going to welcome our guests? Our children?

They all felt the weight of guilt, and the silence that followed was even more oppressive. Catra then turned her gaze to Adora, who wore a slight frown.

— You were so worried about hiding things from me that you forgot to ask for help. Sweetie… there was no way you could control all this on your own.

The blonde closed her eyes and lowered her head. — I… I just wanted you to have a peaceful Christmas. — she murmured. Catra moved closer, cupping the blonde's face and caressing her cheeks.

— I know. The kids told me about the plan. “Operation: Silent Night”, right? — The woman laughed softly, kissing her on the lips.

Adora shook her head, letting out a sigh. — Those kids…

— They were worried about you. Because they know how stubborn their mother can be! — Catra teased, giving the blonde a light slap on the head.

Adora held Catra's hands, lifted her head, and looked up at the sky. Night had already fallen, but time seemed to pass so slowly that it was suffocating. However, she no longer felt that way. With Catra by her side, everything seemed lighter; not even the chaos that the party had turned into could change that.

… But was that really true?

While everyone was talking and trying to clean up what was left of the celebration, a Bright Moon ship flew over the area, causing everyone to stop and watch it. The vehicle landed gently, and everyone was curious about the ship's appearance. Netossa and Spinnerella's eyes widened in surprise when they saw what was behind the door when it opened.

— Wow! What happened here? — asked Netossa, stepping out of the ship alongside his wife and looking around. — I thought it was going to be a Christmas dinner, not an apocalyptic supper. — commented the older woman, letting out a brief chuckle.

— Is everyone okay? — asked Spinnerella, greeting Catra and Adora with a hug before addressing the others.

Everyone remained together, focusing their attention on the two guests. Adora, still perplexed by the situation with the ship, decided to ask once and for all.

— Actually, can you explain what happened there? — the blonde asked, pointing to the front of the ship, where a huge tree trunk had pierced the aircraft.

— Oh, sure. About that… — Netossa scratched the back of her neck, sighing. Spinnerella stood beside her, patting her shoulder before they began to explain.

— A violent snowstorm is hitting the kingdom of Bright Moon. All the roads are covered in snow, and the situation seems to be getting worse by the second. We tried to take off with the ship, but suddenly we were hit by this log. Fortunately, no one was hurt. — Spinnerella explained, and the tension spread again.

— The children are in the castle, but… something else happened. — Netossa said, looking at Catra and Adora. — Isaac is missing.

{…}

Persisting through the cave, Isaac found a piece of branch, using it as support so as not to strain his injured leg. A few meters away, he saw a distinct light. To make sure it wasn't an illusion, Isaac turned off his flashlight. It didn't seem close, but it was real. The little boy's heart rejoiced.

— I knew I could do it… — he murmured, quickening his pace despite the pain. He pressed on, the light growing brighter and brighter, until the ground ended. — **AH!** — Isaac slipped as he clung to a rock at the edge of a vast opening in the middle of the cave.

Isaac hung there, looking down; his body dangled over a dark pit that seemed endless. He took a deep breath, feeling his fingers slip. With his good leg, he hooked his boot into small cracks in the rocks.

With all his strength, he managed to climb up, and when he reached the top, he rolled onto his back, panting heavily, his heart still racing from the scare.

The silence of the cave prevailed once again. Isaac got up, sat down, and stared at the immense cave. There were several tunnels leading to different destinations. He approached the edge, looking up. It was so high that it seemed to swallow the light, so deep that he couldn't see the bottom.

— Wow… — he whispered, standing up but staying away from the edge. Then Isaac rubbed his chin; he began to think, and a smile appeared on his face. — I'm Isaac! — shouted the boy, his voice echoing throughout the room. — I'm awesome! — he shouted again, laughing at his own joke. Then, with his hands on his hips, he let out a deep sigh and looked down. — Jack and Arrow would like that…

As he remembered his family and friends, he heard a noise approaching from behind, accompanied by a warm wind. Faced with heavy footsteps and a hoarse panting, Isaac's body froze.

He tried to turn around, but as he moved just part of his body to face what would emerge from the darkness, he was suddenly pulled into another hole, plunging into complete darkness.

"*No—! What is this?! Let me go!*" Isaac writhed, trying to scream, but his mouth was covered by something soft and firm at the same time.

Isaac froze when he heard a roar that made the entire cave shake. The place fell silent again, and Isaac held his breath as he heard heavy footsteps approaching. The footsteps reached the entrance, and then he could see a large snout with sharp fangs exposed.

The creature advanced, exposing itself completely. A druvok of enormous proportions. Isaac knew what it was, as he had studied magical creatures at school, but he had never seen one up close. And especially one so huge and terrifying.

The druvok sniffed the entrance, but did not enter the room where Isaac was. It continued sniffing around, growling softly,

and when it turned its head, Isaac could see a large scar on the animal's face.

Isaac wanted to move, to escape from that place, but the same thing that covered his mouth enveloped his entire body, keeping him close and out of sight of the druvok. Isaac couldn't identify what was holding him, but it was soft and gave off a slight scent of rain.

Suddenly, another noise arose, alerting the large druvok, who looked at the pit Isaac had almost fallen into. From the depths of the cave, large bats emerged, flying in a group. They flew over the druvok, who quickly attacked them, managing to knock one of them down.

Isaac's eyes widened as he watched, against his will, the druvok immobilize the bat on the ground with both paws, keeping its head free. With its jaws wide open and salivating, the druvok slowly lowered itself; it bit the bat's head completely, twisting it and tearing it off in one go.

Isaac squeezed his eyes shut, turned his face away, and tried to ignore the sound of the beast chewing. His whole body trembled, betraying his struggle not to sob. His heart raced again as tears welled up in his eyes.

— Don't make a sound. He'll be gone soon. — The voice was low and soft. Isaac opened his eyes and saw the druvok carrying the bat away.

When the animal's noise disappeared from the cave, Isaac pulled his arms back and pushed whatever it was away, falling to the ground due to the force he exerted.

— Stay away from me! — he shouted, crawling backward toward a small light coming from a hole.

The creature remained in the darkness, only its eyes visible, watching Isaac calmly. The boy tried to get up to run, but,

overcome by fear, he forgot about his injured leg and fell again, letting out a brief grunt of pain.

Noticing the enigmatic being moving, Isaac turned around, holding a piece of rock in his trembling hand. The creature blinked slowly, moving silently until it was illuminated. Isaac gasped in astonishment at the sight of the huge gray and white feline with vibrant stripes. Its sapphire-blue eyes shone brightly.

— Who are you?

~ Kingdom of Bright Moon, December 22 – 12:04 a.m. ~

The snowstorm ravaged the kingdom more and more, keeping servants and inhabitants of the kingdom trapped in the palace. The soldiers who had left to find Isaac had not yet returned, and fear grew with each passing second.

Mila, like the others, sat on the floor, leaning against the wall of the large hall. The nannies were responsible for the youngest children, as well as providing food and warm clothes for everyone.

Ember rested on her lap as she stroked her youngest daughter's dark brown hair. Finn was also sitting next to her, resting her head on her shoulder, as they waited for news.

Christmas was approaching, and not only had they lost their presents, but Isaac was still missing, without his mother's knowing. At least that's what Mila believed as she tried to close her eyes.

The noise of the ship's jet woke everyone who was sleeping. The guards ran to the entrance and opened the large door to conduct an inspection. Due to the strong wind, the ship was displaced and collided with the castle, causing the structure to shake and frightening the occupants.

After much effort, the ship managed to land. The soldiers formed a protective shield while the princesses headed inside the castle.

As soon as the large doors closed, they immediately went to meet their children.

— Mom! — Flora exclaimed, running into Scorpia's arms.

— Oh, I'm so happy to see that you're okay! — Scorpia said, squeezing her daughter in a tighter hug.

Mermista welcomed her children, as did Glimmer and Bow. The other princesses who were not present remained in Plumeria to try to save Christmas dinner in time, but all with heavy hearts after receiving the news from Isaac.

Ember got up and ran to her mother's as soon as she saw them. Adora picked her up and then pulled Finn in to join the hug.

Mila approached them slowly, and when she met Adora's deep blue eyes, her whole body trembled. Adora moved away from the others and turned to Mila.

— He was after me! I swear! — The tears came without warning. — We went out to look for gifts… he was with me! He was right behind me, and when we got here, he was gone!

Mila continued to back away until she was caught by Adora's strong arms, which enveloped her, providing immediate warmth and comfort.

Adora rested her chin on her daughter's head and stroked her back. — It's not your fault.

— It is my fault… — Mila murmured against her mother's chest, sobbing intensely. — *I'm sorry…!*

Adora stepped back a little and held Mila's face. — It's not your fault, Mila! — the blonde reiterated, running her thumb across her daughter's cheek. It had been a long time since she had seen her cry like that.

Adora let out a deep sigh and felt Catra's hands on her back. As she approached, the woman smiled softly. Catra turned her attention to her eldest daughter, hugging her, while Adora did the same with both of them, calling Ember and Finn to join the embrace.

— Adora, we're ready. — Bow announced, causing the blonde to step away for a moment to wipe her tear-stained face.

— Okay. You come with me, Bow. Netossa and Scorpia head south and north. — Adora instructed. — Each with a group of soldiers, we will expand the search area as much as possible. — They obeyed promptly, each preparing for the intense snowstorm that awaited them outside.

Mila dried her face and, following her mother, declared: — I'm coming too!

— Absolutely not. — the blonde replied seriously, without losing her welcoming gaze. — I need you to stay here and take care of your mother and sisters. — she said, touching Mila's chin and making her look up. — Can you do that?

Mila nodded briefly and hugged her mother again. Adora said goodbye to Finn and Ember with hugs. Then she went to Catra, sealed her lips with a kiss, and whispered a promise to find Isaac. When she turned to the other soldiers, they banged their spears on the ground in unison, awaiting She-Ra's orders.

Adora took a deep breath, and they all headed outside the castle. However, as Scorpia and Netossa's group followed the directions the blonde had given them earlier, Adora heard her name being called from the sky. She raised her head in an attempt to see something, but the strong wind prevented her.

Until everyone was surprised by an intense glow cutting through the clouds, emanating from a Swift Wind inside them. The alicorn plummeted from the sky, but did not allow his body to collide with

the ground. Spreading his wings wide, he fought against the wind and made a clumsy but perfect landing.

— Swift Wind has arrived! — sang the alicorn. Adora and Bow were perplexed, becoming even more surprised by the presence on his back.

— And Sea Hawk too! — shouted the man before collapsing on the floor.

— What are you two doing here? — asked Bow, helping his friend up.

— We got an urgent alert from Perfuma and came right away. We wouldn't miss this for the world. — explained the pirate.

Swift Wind approached the blonde, resting his wing on her shoulder. — No matter how long it takes, we'll find him. I guarantee it!

— Thanks, buddy. — Adora said, climbing onto the alicorn's back. — Bow and Sea Hawk will go by land with the others. Swift Wind and I will go up.

Everyone agreed, and in a few seconds they were already dispersing in the snow, beginning the search for Prince Isaac — without knowing how far away he was.

~ Somewhere ~

Silence dominated the environment, interrupted only by Isaac's restrained breathing. As he stared at the large feline in front of him, time seemed to pass slowly.

"*Crap… now what? This thing won't stop staring at me!*"

Isaac moved his body, leaning slightly from side to side. And, as expected, the feline followed his movements. He let out a deep sigh.

"*Okay, I need to get out of here, or I'll end up becoming dinner!*"

Suddenly, the feline took a few steps toward Isaac, surprising him and causing him to retreat abruptly.

— I don't taste good! — Isaac exclaimed. — My skin is very tough and doesn't taste good. Here, I can show you! — The little boy licked his arm, making a face. — See? It's not tasty at all. — He stood up, trying to keep his balance.

The feline stopped in her tracks, showing no reaction, just staring at him. Isaac cleared his throat and forced a broad smile.

— I'm skinny, and I'm sure you wouldn't like me. So how about I go this way… — The little one pointed the way behind him. — And you go that way? — He pointed ahead. — Are we agreed? — he asked, still with a forced smile.

Once again, the cat didn't move; she just blinked slowly. Isaac was sweating cold, running his hand over his pants. He looked back, then forward.

— So… I'm leaving. And you go that way! — he indicated again, closing his hands and raising his thumbs at the same time. — Okay, all right. I'm leaving now! — As he turned to run, he ended up using his injured leg without realizing it. — Ugh! — he let out a groan of pain, but quickly covered his mouth, looking at the feline. She responded to the sound, bending over and tilting her head gently to the side. — I mean… Arrr! — he struggled to deepen his voice and keep his distance. The feline looked away from his leg, and Isaac did the same, raising his head quickly. — Oh, my leg is fine! It's not hurt, and it definitely doesn't taste good! — To prove his point, he stomped hard on the ground with his injured leg.

As it touched the ground for the first time, a sharp pain shot through his body. Isaac flinched, grimaced again, and swallowed hard, struggling to remain calm.

— See? I'm fine!

The feline blinked again, twitching an ear, and then took its first step toward the boy.

— Hey, hey! Wait! — Isaac jumped back using only one leg, while the feline continued to approach, its gaze fixed on his injured leg.

When Isaac fell to the ground, the feline cornered him against the wall, raising her paw and showing her claws. Isaac closed his eyes, resigned to his fate.

Suddenly, he heard a tearing sound and, when he opened his eyes, he realized it was his own pants being destroyed. The feline used a claw to cut the little boy's pants, just in the leg area, and brought her face closer, sniffing. Isaac tried to move, but felt another sting.

When the cat moved her face away a little, he noticed that his leg was becoming progressively more purple, probably due to the times he had forced it and the cold. Then, without hesitation, she approached him with her jaws open.

— No! I don't taste good! Please! — he exclaimed, covering his eyes. Suddenly, Isaac felt like laughing. He let his hands fall, noticing the cat licking his injured leg. — Hey... hah! That tickles. — he laughed even more, pushing the cat's head away with his hand. Then, an inexplicable glow appeared, reflecting in his eyes, and all the purple on his leg disappeared.

The little boy was stunned, looking at his leg and then at the cat, who just sat and watched him as Isaac got up.

He stamped his foot on the ground with his injured leg and, to his surprise, felt no pain at all. To make sure he was okay, Isaac jumped up and down in the same spot, flashing a broad smile.

— My leg is healed! — he shouted, still jumping, until he slipped and fell on his back. The cat became alert and went to him again. — I'm fine! — he assured her, smiling.

The feline let out a sigh, allowing the little boy to continue jumping. Soon his smile faded, replaced by a curious look. At that moment, it was Isaac who approached the feline, still cautious.

— Who are you? — he asked.

The feline tilted her head slightly. — My name is Thalara. — she replied in a soft, firm, and warm tone of voice. She asked as she sat down: — What are you doing here, little one?

Isaac, head down, looked away. — I was with my sisters looking for Christmas presents. But… I got lost in the snow and fell into a hole. — he explained, sitting down on the floor as well. — Then that thing appeared, and you saved me before it saw me. — he declared. — It was my fault for stopping here! — Isaac rubbed his eyes with his forearm, trying to hide his tears.

Thalara watched Isaac for a moment, then sat closer to him, licking his face and drying his tears.

— Don't worry, little one… Fate wanted us to meet. — declared the imposing feline.

Isaac sniffed. — What do you mean by that?

— I saw you in my visions. Everything will be fine, I'll help you get out of here.

— Really? — he asked, watching Thalara as she grabbed him by the collar of his shirt and lifted him gently.

The sound of the druvok echoed once more through the cave, causing everything to shake. On impulse, Isaac cowered, moving closer to Thalara.

— Don't be afraid, little one. I'm here. — Thalara said in a welcoming voice, positioning herself behind the little boy and gently nudging him with her head, encouraging him to continue down the tunnel.

Chapter 5: Christmas is coming

Chapter Notes

Hello, everyone!
Belated Merry Christmas!
I hope you had an amazing week.

So, with these last two hectic days, I haven't been able to post.
But here we are! I hope you're enjoying it. I'm having a lot of fun writing this end-of-year special.
From January to February, I'll be back with the other fics that are on hold.
Enjoy reading. If you find any mistakes, let me know and I'll fix them later.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

{...}

With his leg fully recovered, Isaac jumped and slid down the ramp-shaped rocks, taking advantage of the fact that the cave was widening.

— Woo-hoo! — he exclaimed, laughing and jumping from rock to rock, while Thalara followed him, keeping an eye on the path ahead and the little prince.

When the ramps and tunnel ended, they came across two new routes. Thalara's ears perked up, turning toward the two entrances, then back to Isaac's footsteps beside her as he walked toward one entrance.

— That's not the right way. — she warned, watching him. With a frown, Isaac turned to her.

— How do you know? — he asked, putting his hands on his hips.
— This path is brighter than that one. — he said, pointing to the

two entrances. — It's definitely the right way. I mean, it's pretty obvious. — he shrugged. The path on the right was lit, while the one on the left was dark.

Thalara approached the little one, looking at the illuminated cave. — The obvious isn't always correct, pup. — she said, standing beside him.

— But this is the best way! — he insisted.

When Isaac moved forward, Thalara wrapped her tail around his waist, pulling him back. He pouted and crossed his arms. Thalara remained calm.

— Things aren't always what they seem. — she said, taking a few steps forward and staring at the illuminated tunnel.

The feline let out a low growl, opening her jaw even wider and roaring loudly. The light illuminating the tunnel began to flicker several times before going out completely. Isaac raised his eyebrows, intrigued by the creatures hanging upside down from the ceiling.

— It's those bats from before! — Isaac pointed out.

Thalara continued to stare calmly at the creatures on the ceiling, which swung frantically and growled before curling up in their own wings.

— These are a little different. — Thalara sat down. — They have a red pattern that distinguishes them from the others. — she explained, nodding her head. — In addition, they have a shiny ball hanging from their heads.

Isaac, curious, tilted his head slightly. — What do they use that for?

— They use that shiny ball to generate a light so intense that it attracts prey. The other animals think it's the way out, when in reality it's the way into their stomachs.

The little boy gasped, impressed. — That's pretty smart. Scary. But smart.

Thalara let out a brief laugh and went the other way. Silence accompanied them for a while, until Isaac spoke again.

— Finn would love that. She loves meeting new magical creatures. — Isaac said suddenly, following Thalara down the dark tunnel, which soon began to light up thanks to holes in the walls that let light in.

— Who's Finn? — asked the feline, stopping in front of a small crack. Thalara assessed the distance between the ends. She turned and grabbed Isaac by the collar of his jacket, jumping with him to the other side and landing on the ground again.

— My older sister. I mean, the second oldest. I have three sisters. — He excitedly held up three fingers. — My mother is pregnant with another one, but we don't know yet if it will be a boy or a girl.

Thalara stopped, sniffing the air, and took a new direction, gently pulling Isaac with her tail when the little boy went the other way, precisely because he wasn't paying attention.

— So you're the youngest? — she asked, helping him climb a stone wall, using her head to push him up. Then she jumped up and continued along the path, which was becoming progressively clearer and colder.

— Actually, I'm the third. My sister Ember is the youngest, for now. — he said, smiling and kicking small stones on the ground.

Suddenly, a cold wind caressed Isaac's face. He hugged himself, shivering slightly, and it was then that he noticed the new light in the distance.

— Thalara, are those bats again? — he asked, turning to her.

The big cat shook her head, and unable to answer, Isaac sprinted toward the light, too confident to hear Thalara.

— Wait, no, cub! — she shouted, running after him.

Isaac looked back, confused, as he continued running. As he crossed the light, his eyes widened when his feet slipped in the air and his body began to fall.

— Thalara! — Isaac's scream tore through the air, and he just closed his eyes.

While Isaac kept his eyes closed and his body curled up, his chest rose and fell intensely. Seconds passed until he finally decided to open his eyes. Looking down, he realized how high up he was.

— **Oh, no! No, no, no!** — He shook his legs in despair until he finally heard Thalara's voice.

— You're a very restless cub. — she said gently, holding him by his jacket.

Isaac looked at the feline and then at the surrounding landscape. — Yeah, my moms say the same thing. — he commented, taking a deep breath.

{...}

Far away, the snowstorm was still raging, tormenting everyone outside and inside the castle.

Everyone was committed to finding the young prince. Still, as Adora continued to advance, the soldiers who were following her began to fall behind.

Bow lowered the mask that covered part of his face and narrowed his eyes in an attempt to see beyond the dense curtain of snow, but it was in vain. He looked back and saw Swift Wind and Sea Hawk joining the soldiers, who were shivering from the cold.

— Isaac! — exclaimed the blonde, her arm in front of her face. — Isaac! — she shouted in another direction. — Isaac! Where are you, baby? — Her voice trembled as she struggled to hold back tears. The cold didn't bother her because, thanks to her powers as She-Ra, she was able to keep herself warm. The same couldn't be said for the others.

Bow was talking to one of the soldiers when he looked at the blonde and approached her.

— Adora, the weather is getting worse. We need to return!

— I'm not going back without my son! — she replied, her face contorted, pushing her friend's hand away. She continued calling for the little boy. — ISAAC! — she shouted, raising her voice.

One of the soldiers approached to Bow, his lips trembling. — Sir, we can't see anything in this storm. — he said. — If we don't go back now, we'll die! — he exclaimed, clutching his coat tightly.

— I can try to fly again. — announced Swift Wind, already spreading his wings.

The alicorn gained momentum and ascended toward the clouds, trying to break through them. However, the strong wind pushed him back. Soon, the relentless ice of the storm stuck to his left wing, causing him to lose control.

— I'm screwed…! — Swift Wind muttered before falling.

Seeing his friend plummet from the sky, Bow exclaimed: — Adora!

The blonde turned around, and as she looked up, she transformed back into She-Ra and jumped. She caught the alicorn, using her body to protect Swift Wind in the fall, and both sank into the snow.

The soldiers ran to the spot where they had fallen, dragging the snow with their hands and shouting their names.

Adora emerged abruptly from the snow, wiping her face. — Swift Wind! — she shouted, turning her sword into a shovel and hastily beginning to pull the snow off the alicorn.

The soldiers approached her, helping the blonde remove the alicorn from the snow. Once they succeeded, Adora was able to breathe a sigh of relief.

— Swift Wind, are you okay, buddy? — asked Sea Hawk.

— 100%! — he replied, flashing a broad smile. However, when he tried to spread his colorful wings, he grimaced in pain. — Or… maybe only 95%… — the alicorn grunted, feeling discomfort in his left wing.

Adora frowned, forgetting her sense of relief. When she touched the alicorn's wing, he recoiled, letting out a hoarse whinny.

The blonde sighed deeply, staring at the grouped guards, then turning to Swift Wind. Aware that she couldn't put more people at risk, Adora made up her mind.

— Sea Hawk and Bow, take everyone back to the castle. — she said, standing up. — Tell Catra and Glimmer that I'm fine and that I don't want anyone to come looking for me.

Adora took one last look at them, saying goodbye, and left alone. However, it didn't take long before she heard Bow's voice in the snow.

— I told you to go back! — the blonde complained, frowning as she saw the man approaching.

— Yes, you did. And they came back, but I'm staying with you! — Bow declared firmly. — And don't say you don't need me. I'm not leaving you here alone! — he exclaimed, fighting against the snow. — And if I did, Catra and Glimmer would kill me. — he added.

Adora raised an eyebrow as she watched her friend continue. She sighed, aware that he was right. And even if they tried to make him turn back, Adora knew how stubborn he could be. So she just shook her head slightly and continued behind him.

~ December 23, 10:25 p.m. ~

After preventing Isaac from falling off the mountain peak, he sat on the edge, gently swinging his feet. Thalara was reclining beside him, contemplating the landscape.

— How did I end up so far away? — he asked, more to himself. The feline's ears turned toward him.

Thalara closed her eyes and inhaled the air. — The storm should stop soon. For now, we should stay here. — she said, opening her mouth and letting out a yawn, followed by a hoarse growl.

Isaac's eyebrows knitted together, and he sighed heavily. — Will I make it home in time for Christmas? — he asked, without looking directly at the feline.

— Don't worry. We'll get there. — she replied, moving the tip of her tail slowly.

Isaac crawled backward and pulled his legs close to his chest. — I've never been away from my mother's for so long… — The comment came suddenly. Thalara raised an eyebrow, attentive to the little one's subtle movements. — Do you think they miss me? Or… are they really looking for me?

— Of course they're looking for you, little one. — Thalara replied, turning her head to look at Isaac. Noticing the tears forming in his eyes, she stood up and approached him. — Why are you doubting?

The young prince hugged his legs even tighter, fiddling with his boot laces. — It's just… sometimes I feel like I don't belong in this family. — He let out a long sigh. — I keep saying I'm a GraysKull, but I don't even have powers like my mother Adora. Or claws,

fangs, a tail, or ears like my mother Catra. — Isaac gestured, lowering his hands. — The only trait I inherited from my mother Catra is my brown hair. Other than that, I'm just…

Thalara tilted her head gently as she watched Isaac hide his face and sniffle quietly. She waited for the little boy, looking away at the landscape.

— I'm just a human. — he murmured.

Silence fell, broken only by the cat's controlled breathing and Isaac's stifled sobs. A cold wind made the little boy cower again, clutching his clothes to keep warm. At the same time, Thalara's tail slowly moved closer to him.

— But you wouldn't be talking to me if you didn't have magic. — she replied, surprising Isaac.

He frowned, perplexed, and stared at the feline. — What?

— Precisely. Only other magical beings can communicate with me. Especially Magicats. — she said.

— Magicats? — he asked, scratching his head.

— Of course. I'm surprised they still exist.

Isaac raised his eyebrows, watching the feline's face closely.

— Wait… you don't move your mouth to talk to me! — he exclaimed, open-mouthed. — So it's true? — Isaac jumped up and down. — I'm half Magicat! — he exclaimed excitedly.

Thalara smiled and sat down facing the little boy. — It's been a long time since I've met a Magicat. Especially a half-human one. — She laughed softly and began to lick his face. — And here you are. An impulsive cub, but with a big heart.

Isaac slowly fell backward as Thalara positioned herself on top of him. Due to her soft fur, the little boy laughed, feeling tickled.

Thalara stopped, moved away from him, and lay down again. Isaac wiped his face, and his tears of sadness gave way to joy. The feline sighed deeply.

— Just as every seed has it's time to germinate, some powers blossom later than others. — she explained calmly. — Just because you're different doesn't mean you're inferior. You're unique in your own way.

Isaac filled his lungs with air, looking at the horizon, and a radiant smile spread across his face. Now his heartfelt lighter.

As time passed, the snow began to fall less intensely, making Isaac increasingly eager to leave that cave. It was then that the little boy noticed Thalara's gaze on him.

He tilted his head slightly. — What is it? — he asked, and then his eyes widened in terror. — Is there a spider on me?!

— There are no spiders. — the feline replied, watching the little boy's expression soften and a sigh of relief escape him. — You mentioned that you are a GraysKull, right? — she asked, crossing her paws.

— Exactly. — he confirmed.

Thalara looked away, while Isaac watched her, intrigued by her serious expression. The little boy then moved closer to her and asked:

— What happened?

— I met a GraysKull…

Isaac jumped up, excited. — So you know my mom?

— No. — she replied quickly, interrupting any other ideas the little boy might have had. Isaac's expression clouded over with disappointment, and he simply sat down again.

He turned to face her, crossing his legs as he waited for Thalara to continue her explanation. The feline looked at him sideways, finding his interest admirable.

— The GraysKull I met was not a woman. It was a man. — she revealed, her eyes fixed on the falling snow, seeing beyond it. — That was many moons ago. Unfortunately, this story does not have a happy ending.

— So what happened? — he asked, his eyebrows slightly furrowed.

— The man, known as He-Man, unfortunately had his beloved cruelly torn from him, and this drove him mad. — she said, and in her eyes, though Isaac could not see it, the flames of an ancient war burned. — The hero's heart was corrupted by pain. This resulted in a massacre, where many perished. — Thus, the land where they lived was plunged into suffering, until it was finally abandoned.

Isaac let his shoulders slump, trying to imagine it, but something like that, no child should or could conceive. The pain of loss. The anger. And the uncontrollable longing to recover what was lost.

No one should have to go through that.

— What happened to him? — Isaac asked.

Faced with the sudden silence, he leaned in to observe Thalara's face. The feline had a distant look and blinked slowly, responding to Isaac's touch. Her fur bristled for a moment in surprise, then she looked back at the little boy. Isaac gazed at her gently, keeping his hand on her arm.

Thalara took a deep breath, and the scent of ashes still lingered in her nostrils.

— He's gone, Isaac. — she said in a deep tone, laden with a past full of suffering. — For living in a world without his beloved was *worse* than facing death itself.

Isaac looked away and lowered his hand, watching the falling snow. — That's very sad… — he whispered.

Thalara's tail moved and wrapped around Isaac's waist. The feline took a deep breath, feeling the little one's head resting on her arm.

{…}

The storm let up in the afternoon, but that didn't mean the search for Isaac became any easier. The accumulated snow covered the kingdom, making it difficult to cross the forest.

— Wait, haven't we already looked here? — Bow asked as he passed a tree with a fallen branch.

Adora frowned and scanned the area. She took her tablet out of her jacket to check. — Maybe we did… Damn it! — She tapped the device's screen, but only a spinning sphere appeared.

— The tower must have been hit by the storm. That's why we can't map the area. — Bow explained, borrowing the tablet and holding it up in an attempt to find a signal.

Adora moved away from him, searching for something unknown that would lead them down a different path. At the same time, Bow slowly backed away, raising the tablet as high as his arms would allow. He continued walking backward until he could no longer find the ground.

— Adora!

The man's cry reached the blonde, who immediately ran toward the gorge. She threw herself to the ground, slid across the snow, and managed to grab his hand.

They remained there for a few seconds, just taking at the moment that could have been so much more tragic. Adora pulled Bow back up, and the two fell backward into the snow, catching their breath after the scare.

— Man… you need to be more careful. I don't want to lose you in the snow too! — Adora declared, panting.

They got up after a while, but when Bow tried to walk, his foot bumped into something. He looked away, crouched down again, and stuck his hand in the snow.

— Adora, I found something! — he shouted, removing the snow from on top. Adora approached, intrigued, until the man removed the item from the snow. — This is…

— It's Isaac's! — The blonde took the flare from his hands.

Bow got up, rubbing his hands to remove the snow. — You gave him a flare?

— It wasn't me… — She let out a weak laugh, feeling tears welling up in her eyes again. — Mila gave them to each of them. She always makes sure they have something to call for help if they get lost. — said the blonde, remembering the day Mila gave the other siblings flares.

— How thoughtful. — Bow praised her. — So that means he was here!

Adora raised her head and turned her body, looking around. — Maybe he tried to climb a tree to signal. — she observed, walking quickly until she stopped at the edge of the gorge.

Adora put her hand to her chest, feeling a sharp pain, and suddenly found it difficult to breathe.

— Bow… do you think he…

— No! — exclaimed Bow, placing his hand on the blonde's shoulder. — He definitely didn't fall. Now we have a clue. Let's go this way! — He pointed in the opposite direction. — Isaac is smart. He must be fine and just waiting for us to find him. So let's go! — Bow said with a hopeful look, patting the blonde on the shoulder.

Adora sighed heavily but agreed. Bow smiled at the blonde, but when he saw her go the other way, he turned back to face the gorge.

"*Please, God, let him be okay…*" the man thought, swallowing hard as he ran to catch up with the blonde.

Chapter End Notes

For those who arrived at the end, I will explain a few important things.

First thing: Catra's relationship with the Magicats.

In the series, Catra has no connection to the Magicats. She is just a woman with cat-like characteristics. However, in this fic, Catra IS a descendant of the Magicats.

I just wanted to explain in case anyone had any questions.

I'll say it again. Yes! Catra, IN THIS FANFICTION, is a descendant of the Magicats.

Will He-Man appear in the fanfiction?

Unfortunately not, and I'll tell you why.

So, we're not talking about Adam, Adora's twin brother. In this fic, he doesn't exist in this timeline. This He-Man from Thalara's story is from a completely different UNIVERSE.

About the bats?

Well, they are large bats, and there are several types. (Honestly, I thought of a cool name for them, but I'll fix that later).

Anyway, that's it for now. I hope you enjoyed it, and I'll see you guys another time.

Chapter 6: Merry Christmas

Chapter Notes

I think it should be Happy New Year. But it's okay.
A goal to achieve in this new year: Get more organized and don't lose my mind.

I hope you have a happy new year. I'll probably post chapter 7 on January 2nd. I think it will be the last chapter, but I'm not sure.
As I said: this year, I want to be more organized than I already am.

Anyway, I hope you like it, soon we'll find out who Thalara really is.

(I said there would be 5 chapters, and we're already reaching 10 lol sorry!)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

~ Bright Moon Castle, December 23 ~

With half of the princesses in the castle and the rest in Plumeria, work was proceeding smoothly. Despite their anguish at still not having received any news about little Isaac, no one had lost hope.

Flora walked through the castle, greeting the people she met along the way. She climbed the stairs to the top of one of the towers, where she knew Finn would be.

As soon as she saw him, Flora smiled. — Hi, Finn!

The young man was sitting by the window, one leg tucked up to his chest, the other dangling loosely. Flora moved closer, still smiling.

— My mother and Aunt Mermista made hot chocolate for everyone. — she said, waiting for Finn to come down.

— Thanks. — he said, holding the mug. — Has Aunt Netossa arrived yet?

— Yes, they came back half an hour ago. — she replied, leaning against the wall as she watched Finn try the drink.

— The castle is quiet… — Finn observed.

— Yes… Everyone is gathered in the main hall. The guards have set the dinner table for everyone who has arrived. The aunts are trying to get Jasper and Arrow to eat.

Finn looked away. Since they had awakened, the little ones had refused to eat anything until Isaac returned. Flora understood, but she was trying to look at the situation optimistically. As Perfuma had always instructed her.

Flora closed her eyes and meditated. "*Breathe, Flora. Let the negative thoughts go*", she breathed deeply as she opened her eyes and smiled again.

— How are you feeling? — she asked.

Finn raised his eyebrows, sighed heavily, and leaned against the window. — I should have kept an eye on him. Then none of this would have happened! — Finn declared, clenching his left fist.

Flora's smile faded, and she pressed her lips together. — But Finn, even if you had stayed on his team, maybe it still would have happened. You can't predict something like that.

— And what do you know?! — Finn suddenly shouted, causing Flora to take a few steps back. Realizing what she had done, the young woman widened her eyes and stepped back as well. — I'm sorry… I didn't mean to yell at you. I just…

Flora watched Finn's chest rise and fall unevenly. She frowned, took a deep breath, and stepped forward. Finn was surprised by Flora's sudden movement and held her breath for a second.

The flower princess wrapped her arms around Finn, holding her in a comforting embrace — even though Finn's body wanted to pull away, she didn't let go.

— I know it's been hard, but Isaac is… Isaac! — she laughed softly, maintaining the embrace. — Remember when he was younger and banged his head several times on the same tree because he insisted he could walk through the trunk? — Flora recalled, hearing Finn's low laughter and feeling her hands hesitantly grip her clothes.

— He hit it so hard that he lost his sense of direction. — Finn commented, amused, squeezing Flora's waist tighter.

— And remember when he found treasure in a cave in Salineas? — Flora continued, feeling warmer, but it wasn't just the heat of his body.

Finn sighed, frustrated that the cup of hot chocolate was getting in the way of their embrace. Without breaking contact, Finn turned their bodies and left the cup on the window sill.

— He spent the whole night telling our mothers how he found the treasure all by himself. — Finn laughed, resting her head on Flora's shoulder.

They laughed even more as they recalled all of Isaac's adventures and mischief. Even in his absence, he still managed to make everyone laugh a lot.

Flora slowly moved away, stroking Finn's shoulders, and smiled gently. She smoothed Finn's face, tucking a strand of hair behind his ear.

— I shouldn't say this, but Isaac is always complaining about how you take care of everyone else and always forget about yourself.

— she commented.

— Maybe I'm a little stubborn.

— A little? — Flora raised an eyebrow, flashing a mischievous smile.

— Oh, give me a break… — Finn pushed her away gently, staring at her with slightly flushed cheeks.

Flora approached him again, holding Finn's hands. — But he's right. You're always taking care of everyone else, so let us take care of you for a change. — she said, looking up to meet Finn's eyes. — Let *me* take care of you…!

She moved dangerously closer, looking at Finn's lips and then into his eyes. Finn swallowed hard, his breathing uneven, unable to look away from Flora's lips as his heart raced in his chest.

Just as Finn was about to give in to the moment, a sudden flash surprised them, causing them to look down the hallway where Flora had come from earlier.

— Wow, this is going down in history! — Miranda said with a big smile as the photo printed out from the camera.

— Hey! Miranda, give me that! — Finn shot after his friend.

Flora was still processing what had just happened, but when she returned, she was completely red. She started laughing to herself and then ran after the two.

The trio descended the tower stairs and ran through the castle corridors, with Miranda shouting about Finn and Flora, until they reached the great hall.

The unexpected entrance of the three young people and all the commotion frightened those in the room.

— Mira, give me that camera! — Finn shouted once again.

Mira slid under the table to the other side with ease, raising the camera again just to tease Finn. The young woman's face was already as red as a bell pepper.

— Miranda, throw it here! — Flora asked, laughing for no reason, while waving her arms up, ignoring Finn's frown.

— Ugh! Are you serious, Flora?! — Finn exclaimed.

Miranda threw the camera to Flora, who was on the other side of the table, and the young woman ran hastily to escape Finn.

— Hey! That's my camera! — Jasper exclaimed, looking annoyed. — Miranda, I told you not to touch my stuff! — She got up from the table and started chasing her.

As the excitement spread, Jack and Arrow looked at each other, grinning broadly. They jumped out of their chairs and joined in the chaos that had taken over the room.

As the mothers tried to get the young people to stop, Sam let out a giggle, pushed his chair back, and stood up.

— Mom, I'm going to look for Mila. — Sam informed Mermista as he grabbed two mugs of hot chocolate. He left the hall, and the door closed slowly, accompanied only by the sound of voices.

He searched the castle for his girlfriend; he asked some employees, who pointed to the room where the gifts were supposed to be — *and the disappearance remained a mystery.*

When he opened the door, Sam saw Mila facing an open window. He smiled as he closed the door with his hip.

— Hi, star of my life! — Sam said, approaching her and kissing her on the cheek. Mila sighed, flashing a discreet smile. — I brought you hot chocolate. With four perfect marshmallows. Just the way you like it. — he said enthusiastically, handing her the mug.

Mila didn't answer, just thanked him with a faint, discouraged smile, took a sip of her drink, and then set it aside.

Sam sighed, looking at the mug left in the corner, and then stopped drinking too. He approached Mila, gently touched her hand, and brought it to his lips.

— Mila… you can't act like this.

Mila shook her head and pushed his hand away. — How do you want me to be?! — she exclaimed, her eyes heavy and red. — I lost him! It's my fault!

Sam took a deep breath. — Mila…

— I should have paid more attention. Now he's God knows where, and it's all because of me! — She backed away, running her hands through her hair and pulling at the blonde strands at the nape of her neck.

Tears were already streaming down her face, and the young woman's chest rose and fell slowly and painfully.

Sam couldn't bear to see Mila like this. He grabbed his girlfriend by the wrist, pulling her close, and hugged her tightly. As expected, Mila shed all the tears she had been holding back since Adora left to look for Isaac.

— Honey… you're blaming yourself, but who better to survive out there than him? — he said, holding his girlfriend's face and wiping her tears. — And do you know why I say that with certainty? — he asked. — Because you taught Isaac everything he knows!

Mila held back her tears and looked at Sam with a confused expression. — What? What are you talking about?

— Everything! — Sam gestured, letting go of her face. Then he picked up the mug of hot chocolate again and handed it to her. — Not to take anything away from your mothers. Aunties are wonderful. But you, Mila, were the one who taught Isaac

everything he knows. — He pulled out a box and sat down. — Remember when you broke your leg falling out of a tree while we were organizing a surprise party for Miranda?

Mila nodded, took a sip of chocolate, and leaned against the wall, listening attentively to her boyfriend.

— Isaac tried to take you to the castle by himself, but you ended up falling into a hole. He broke his arm, and even though he wanted to cry from the pain, he didn't. All because he wanted to show how strong he was, just to impress you.

The young woman let out a short laugh through her nose, looking at the half-empty mug. As Sam spoke, she continued drinking.

— And when he turned three months old, you made him a mini-axe because you wanted him to learn how to defend himself from all dangers.

— Heh, Mom Adora almost had a heart attack that day… — Mila remembered, smiling more broadly. — Sam… I know what you’re doing. But that doesn’t change anything…

— Maybe not. But that's not the point. The point here is that Isaac is strong. And you're the one who taught him that strength! — Sam pointed out, his eyes sparkling. — You're an amazing older sister who tries her hardest to keep everyone safe. In fact, Finn takes after you in that regard. — Sam commented, amused, standing up to kiss Mila on the forehead. — You and Finn are great older siblings. So please, just for a moment, stop acting like you can handle everything on your own.

Mila sighed deeply, setting her empty mug aside, and hugged her boyfriend. Mila snuggled into the embrace, resting her ear against his chest, and for the first time allowed her body to relax.

— Thank you, love.

— You're welcome. Just remember that you're not alone, okay? — he replied, kissing the top of Mila's head.

{...}

After talking to Sam, Mila went to the other side of the castle, where she found her mother in the old room they used to live in when they still lived in Bright Moon.

Catra was lying in the hammock with Ember, humming softly as she stroked her daughter's hair. When she saw Mila at the door, Catra smiled affectionately and called her over with a slight wave.

Mila hesitated for a moment, but when Finn appeared at her side, they smiled at each other. The older girl put her arm around Finn's shoulders, and the two walked over to their mother and lay down.

Catra caressed Mila's face and, looking at Finn, kissed her daughter's head. After settling them in the hammock, she continued to sing until they all fell asleep.

~ December 23, 4:51 p.m. ~

The journey down the mountain took more out of Isaac than he would admit. Aware that the little one was slightly stubborn, Thalara began searching for food as soon as they left the foot of the mountain.

After a while, Thalara finally spotted a large, sturdy rabbit. The feline crouched among the snow-covered bushes — her gaze fixed on her target. Isaac was crouched beside her, grimacing.

— What's wrong, cub? Don't you like rabbits? — she asked, looking at him sideways.

— Well… yes, I do. But not dead ones! — he exclaimed in a whisper. — And I don't want to eat them raw, either. — Isaac swallowed hard.

The rabbit grazed peacefully, unaware that the two were there. Isaac watched Thalara, who was already showing her claws and moving her shoulders slowly, ready to attack.

Isaac lowered his head and took a deep breath. — No! I can't do it! — he suddenly exclaimed. — Run, little bunny! — Isaac jumped out of the bushes, scaring the rabbit, which ran away to its burrow.

When everything calmed down, he turned around and didn't see Thalara. Despair took hold, and he ran to the bush where he had been hiding, thinking he had been abandoned. His fear disappeared when he heard a noise coming from further ahead and saw the feline dragging her paws in a pile of accumulated snow.

— Did you catch another rabbit…? — he asked, afraid to approach Thalara. However, the feline turned to him and settled down, signaling for the little one to come closer.

— I found some more food. You may not like it at first, but it's the best I can do for you right now. — she explained, dragging her paw in the snow. The thick layer was removed, revealing pieces of dry roots.

Isaac looked at the roots and then turned his gaze to Thalara. The feline looked at the roots and then at the little boy, and it was at that moment that Isaac understood.

— Wait! You want me to eat that? Are you sure? Won't it hurt me? — The questions came quickly as the little boy took a few steps back.

— We can try to find something else, but our journey is long, and you haven't eaten in a long time. — she explained calmly, looking for more roots that might satisfy him.

Isaac didn't like the idea, but he recognized that the feline was right. His stomach betrayed him by growling loudly, causing him to cover his belly and blush with embarrassment.

— All right, I'll try it. — He pulled out the root and examined it carefully.

After taking a deep breath, Isaac closed his eyes and opened his mouth. He chewed for a while before he could swallow, opening his eyes and raising his eyebrows.

— Wow… it's not so bad! — he exclaimed, his eyes shining, and continued eating.

Thalara stood up, walked a little further, and stopped at the edge of a frozen lake. She touched the ice to check its thickness. Isaac followed close behind, finishing his meal of roots and wiping his hands on his clothes.

— Wait a minute. — she ordered, stepping on the ice with her front paws. Then she stood up, leaning on her hind legs, before letting the front of her body crash down hard and break the ice.

Isaac gasped in surprise and approached the edge as well. When he saw the water, he smiled. Thalara stood beside him, giving him space.

— Drink first. Even in the cold, it's essential to keep your body hydrated. — she recited patiently, waiting for him to bend down to drink water.

Isaac cupped his hands and brought the water to his mouth, taking a big gulp. — This is so good! — he exclaimed, taking more.

Thalara sighed with relief, and only then crouched down to drink water. Before he was completely satisfied, Isaac watched the way the feline drank water. Curious, he rested his hands on the ice and tried to imitate Thalara, lowering his head and pulling the water with his tongue — which didn't work very well.

Frustrated, he gave up, returning to drinking water as he had been doing before, and followed the big feline when she finished. Then they resumed their walk to Bright Moon Castle.

As night fell, the hours of walking began to take their toll. Thalara looked back and saw the little one struggling to walk and keep his

eyes open.

The cat looked around, sniffing. Then she turned to Isaac and grabbed him by the collar of his jacket. Thalara carried him and, after walking a little, found refuge inside a huge fallen tree.

She left him there and, upon leaving, began to collect some leaves, bringing them inside and organizing everything. Isaac watched what she was doing and, although he didn't fully understand, he went out and did the same.

The prince picked up a few more leaves, placing everything inside the trunk, and in a short time, the pile of leaves turned into a nest. He lay down, satisfied with the work he had done.

Thalara lay down beside him, focusing on the outside of the makeshift den and entering a state of vigilance. Isaac rolled around in the leaves, playing, oblivious to the feline's behavior. After a while, he got tired, removed the leaves that were stuck in his hair, and yawned.

— Thalara, why do you talk like an old woman? — The question surprised the feline and made her turn her face to face him.

The huge feline raised an eyebrow, and Isaac immediately raised his hands.

— Sorry! I didn't mean to be rude. — He smiled awkwardly, shrugged his shoulders, and waited for the reprimand. However, that's not what happened.

Thalara laughed. It was the first time she had truly laughed since they met. A sincere, gentle, and somewhat naive laugh. That laugh reminded Isaac of his mother, Catra, and how similar they were.

The feline let out a long sigh, recovering, and turned her gaze back to the night sky.

— Yes, Isaac, I am old. But I still consider myself young. — replied the feline, good-humoredly, snuggling deeper into the nest and placing one paw over the other.

Isaac laughed briefly. — Mom Adora always says the same thing. But she can't keep up with us on the trail, heh! — They both laughed. — Then she complains: 'My muscles are gone!' and Mama Catra replies: 'You're still perfect, dear.' — Isaac recited in a high-pitched voice, imitating the way mothers talk, making the feline laugh again.

— Well, this entire planet is still a baby. — Thalara said.

— Baby? — Isaac repeated, confused.

— Yes, cub. For me, time is different from yours. — She looked outside, where snowflakes were beginning to fall again. — The past, present, and future are the same thing in my view.

Isaac crawled closer to Thalara, watching the sky as she did.

— Why is it different for you? — Isaac asked curiously after a brief silence.

Thalara took a deep breath. — Have you noticed that I'm much bigger than a normal cat on your planet? — she asked, looking at the little one. Before answering, he assessed Thalara. The young prince observed the feline's size, reflected for a moment, and then agreed.

— Yes, you are very big! — he stretched out his arms to demonstrate.

— There is a reason for that. I do not belong to this world, cub.

— Are you from another planet? Like the animals my mom rescued?

— No, little one… — She leaned closer to him and whispered in his ear. — I come… *from the stars!*

Chapter End Notes

Fun fact: I was inspired by the movie Bambi to write this chapter.

If you can help me out with a coffee, I need a new computer. There's a link on my Instagram: @10_garlogan <3

Chapter 7: There are days when you feel like giving up

Chapter Notes

Hi, everyone!

We've reached the penultimate chapter. I'll finish the fic on Monday or Tuesday.
I hope you enjoyed it. If you find any mistakes, let me know and I'll review it later.
All chapters will be released on my Ko-fi soon, with artwork I found on Pinterest to create the animals, as well as some extras.
That's all for now.

{...}

Isaac remained completely paralyzed, his mouth open and his eyebrows raised. He stared at her for a long time, and before any insects could enter the little boy's mouth, Thalara's tail slid under his chin and closed his lips.

— Did you come from the stars?! — he shouted, startling the animals passing by outside. — Wait, that doesn't make sense. Stars are balls of fire. So how did you ‘come’ from the stars?

Thalara let out a low chuckle as she noticed the little boy's furrowed brow, almost able to imagine the gears in his head working intensely to put the pieces together.

— Not technically from the stars. I live up there, Isaac. — she explained, gazing at the stars. — When people look up at the sky, they usually make wishes, try to understand and learn more about space, or pray to gods. — The air slowly left the feline's nostrils. — But what humans don't know is that there is a group of beings who constantly watch them.

Isaac was struggling to understand. However, when he looked at Thalara, his furrowed brow smoothed out, and he became more curious. The large feline gazed at the sky with a weary, melancholic, and lonely look.

— We are the spectators. — the feline revealed. — We are the eyes that observe everything that happens down here.

— Wow! That's crazy… — Isaac whispered.

— Everything that happens down here was written by those above. — she recited. — The first love in someone's life. A person's success after years of effort. Or deliverance from a terrible death. From a mere coincidence to a great conflict… everything was predestined to occur.

The icy wind blew, causing the snow on the ground to rise in a white dust, as if dancing with the air. Thalara looked away at the snow, watching the shapes of other beings playing before disappearing.

Despite the gentleness of the moment, Isaac still perceived a certain weight in the imposing feline's gaze. The sparkle in her eyes generated more confusion than clarity.

The little boy lowered his head and began to play with his fingers. Thalara's ears turned in his direction, watching his movements, and then she took a deep breath.

— Those above cannot stop working, and to watch over you, they created us. — The feline stood up, stretching her body and exposing her claws, while opening her mouth and emitting a yawn followed by a hoarse roar.

— So you watch us all the time?

— Exactly. — she said, settling down and wrapping her tail around the little one. — There were five of us. We watched the humans and reported everything we saw, heard, and learned to the great ones.

The two began to stare at a group of squirrels on top of a tree. They flew from one side to the other, carrying food in their mouths. Isaac smiled, finding the animals' fat cheeks funny.

— Wait… — Isaac said suddenly. — Why are you here if you should be up there? — The little one asked, looking back at the big cat.

— Every 500,000 years, the spectators demand a new heir. So one day, these heirs took our place. — she explained. — But… last time… — The cat paused, lowering her head.

Isaac stood up, reaching out and touching the feline's arm. He caressed her, lowering his gaze as well.

— I descended from the heavens to give birth, but an attack from the darkness claimed the lives of three of the spectators. — she said, looking up again, now colder than the snow falling outside. — Of the five of us, only two survived. Me and Ursa Major.

The young prince grimaced for a second. — Ursa? Are you talking about Ursa Major? That constellation I see in the sky?

— Yes, that's her. — she replied simply.

— And Ursa Minor? — asked the curious little boy, even in the face of the feline's distant gaze.

— She is her heir. One day, she will cease to be the Little Bear and take her mother's place.

They returned to silence. Although the little boy had questions in mind, he did not want to be intrusive. As he looked at Thalara, he noticed the intensity in her gaze and how her breathing had slowed.

Isaac settled back down, keeping his hand on the cat's fur as the night slowly progressed.

— Thalara… — Isaac whispered her name. — Why are you here? — The large feline did not respond immediately. She lay down again, resting her head on her paws, while Isaac lay down beside her, keeping a certain distance between them, despite his trembling touch. After a while, she replied:

— The same evil that struck the spectators pursued me and took my cubs and my mate. Now… I am the last of my kind.

Isaac swallowed hard, pulling his hand away from the feline and turning his back to her, trying to take in everything that had been said. With that, the fatigue from the walk hit him again, and sleep made his eyelids heavy. However, he didn't want to fall asleep yet.

— Go to sleep, little one, the journey is long. — Thalara said, as if she could read his thoughts.

— But I'm not sleepy! — Isaac grumbled, trying to stifle a yawn.

Thalara didn't answer, she just closed her eyes. The cold night breeze whispered through the trees, and even without seeing, the feline's ears were alert to any unfamiliar sounds.

— Thalara…? — the little one's voice sounded again, but softer due to sleepiness. The feline did not open her eyes, only moved her left ear in his direction. — I'm sorry about your kittens. I'm sure you were a great mother.

With that, Isaac's voice disappeared, replaced by soft snoring, while the feline let out a deep sigh.

...

Thalara was awakened by an unfamiliar sound hours after Isaac had fallen asleep. She raised her head, looking outside the den, and saw a black wolf.

He walked with his head down, his nose in the snow, sniffing for something. The two were in the den when the wolf saw them. He growled, baring his sharp fangs.

Thalara did not react, just stared intently at the wolf. Her eyes shone brightly, causing the wolf to stop growling and lower his body until his belly touched the ground. He let out a soft whimper, and then the feline waved toward a path, indicating for the wolf to follow, knowing that he would find food there.

The black wolf rose slowly, first looking in the direction she had pointed, then at the feline. He nodded slightly and then left.

— *Mommy...*

Thalara felt Isaac's touch again and turned her head to look at him. The little boy's body was shivering from the bitter cold of dawn, and although the leaves offered some shelter, it was still not enough.

Isaac, still sleepy, grumbled a little more, pouting slyly. Then, the big cat grabbed him again by his jacket, pulling him closer to her. She laid her head on the leaves and put an arm and her tail over his body to keep him warm.

Isaac wrapped his arm around the feline, causing her to open only one eye, which she soon closed again as she rested her head on his and fell into a deep sleep.

~ December 24, 1:37 p.m. ~

The search for Isaac took Adora and Bow to several locations, but they found nothing to point them in the right direction. With exhaustion weighing heavily on them, Bow suggested they return to regroup and devise a new strategy, since the storm had subsided. However, Adora disagreed and insisted on continuing. Bow knew the blonde well enough to know she wouldn't listen to him. However, there was someone she would listen to.

While Adora explored the interior of a cave, Bow looked for a place with good reception and made a call to the castle. As soon as the blonde came out of the cave, Bow surprised her by throwing the tablet into her arms.

— Did you get a signal? — she asked, somewhat confused, then a smile lit up her face. — That's great! Now we can map the area and try other spots we haven't been to yet. Isaac must be in one of those areas and… Catra?

Adora paused, looking at the tablet more closely. Catra was on the other end of the line, her face furrowed, and her eyes filled with concern.

— Adora, you guys have to come back. Let's come up with another plan. — she said seriously.

The blonde frowned. — I promised to come back with Isaac. — she replied, lowering the tablet and resuming her walk, with Bow following her.

Catra let out a heavy sigh. — I know, Adora. But you're just going to wear yourself out! — she said, softening her voice. — Honey, look at me… — Adora stopped walking, swallowed hard, and then raised the tablet again. — You know our son and how strong he is. I know it's been hard, don't you think I'm crazy too? — declared the feline woman, her eyes welling up with tears. — But I need you here, Adora. Please come home and let's think of a new plan together!

The blonde pondered, her heart torn by the pain of still not having found her son. However, Catra was right. Everyone was right. If she persisted, she would end up exhausted and unable to find Isaac. They required a new strategy.

Finally, Adora gave in and agreed to return. However, when Catra said that a ship would come to pick them up, Adora disagreed, arguing that retracing their steps might lead to some new clues. Catra allowed it, although she did not approve.

{…}

As they walked, Isaac was drawing in the snow with a stick when he heard an intriguing sound coming from behind some bushes.

When he tried to get closer, the snow gave way, and he slipped, rolling down the slope.

The young prince lifted his face, shook his head to remove the snow, and sat up to brush off his clothes.

— Thalara? — he shouted, looking at the small slope from which she had fallen.

Once again, the sound of moving leaves caught Isaac's attention, and behind the trees appeared a colossal vaelion — so large that its horns dragged the snow from the branches as it passed. Its thick coat accentuated its chest, and its piercing black eyes watched Isaac intently.

The immense vaelion shifted from its position, shaking its horns and stamping its feet firmly on the ground.

— H-Hey! Wait, I'm not your enemy! — Isaac tried to get up, but froze when he heard the animal emit a deep roar, as deep as muffled thunder in the forest.

The vaelion pointed its horns at the small man, moving its head up and down. Without hesitation, Isaac ran toward the slope. He tried to climb it, but the snow gave way under his feet, causing him to slip.

A loud snort echoed, and when Isaac looked over his shoulder, his eyes widened. He spun his body and jumped to the side at the last second, staring in terror at the vaelion with its horns stuck in the snow.

The vaelion pushed the snow up, pulling its horns out, and positioned itself with its legs spread apart, pointing its sharp horns in Isaac's direction. It dragged its hoof across the ground, snorting so hard that air came out of its snout like smoke. Then the vaelion lunged voraciously.

Isaac wanted to run, but fear paralyzed him. The only thing he could do at that moment was close his eyes and scream.

— **THALARA!**

Isaac only opened his eyes when he heard Thalara's roar. The young prince gasped, crawling backward as he watched the huge feline roar at the other animal.

Thalara positioned herself between the two, her body arched, claws outstretched, and fur bristling. The two animals growled at each other, while Thalara advanced with her claws, the vaelion used its sharp horns.

The feline continued to roar, but gradually began to back away. She did not intend to hurt the vaelion; she just wanted him to stop attacking Isaac. As a result, it did not take long for the entire forest to fall silent. The only constant sounds were Isaac's irregular breathing and the noises made by the two animals.

The vaelion's chest rose and fell slowly. As he raised his head further, he stiffened his chest. He brought his legs together again, tilting his face slightly downward, and stared at Isaac for a few moments.

Then, without further ado, the vaelion snorted one last time at Thalara, a warning she understood perfectly, and left, crossing the forest and disappearing among the trees.

— Are you okay, cub? — Thalara asked, turning around and sniffing him while looking for possible injuries.

— Am I okay? That thing almost killed me! — Isaac exclaimed, frowning.

Thalara sat down, looking around. — He was just protecting the herd.

— What herd? He's here alone. — Isaac twisted his lips slightly, upset.

— There's a group of them grazing over there. — The feline nodded in the same direction the vaelion had gone. — The leader

was probably herding the area when you showed up. — Thalara explained. — He was just doing what a leader should do. — Thalara stood up and resumed walking.

Isaac also stood up, but when a low groan escaped his lips, Thalara's ears moved back. She turned part of her body and stared at Isaac lying on the ground again. Realizing that the feline was staring at him, he immediately tried to wipe his face.

— I'm fine. My leg just went numb. — he hastened to say as the feline approached him.

— There's no shame in crying because you're scared. — she said softly, rubbing her snout against his face. Isaac sniffed and lowered his head into the snow, covering part of his face.

— I'm tired of walking… — he murmured, lying face down. Thalara remained by his side, opening her mouth and holding him by the waist.

The young prince's eyes widened as he was lifted off the ground, part of his body in the mouth of the huge feline, who continued on her way through the snow.

Isaac gasped when he saw Thalara's sharp teeth, but they didn't hurt him. The journey continued in silence, and while being carried, Isaac saw a fox with her cub. He smiled and waved at the animal, who simply nodded, picked up her cub in her mouth — just as Thalara had done with Isaac — and disappeared into the forest.

After thirty minutes of walking, Thalara climbed a small mountain, paused on a large rock, and placed the little boy on the ground. As he looked around, he was startled by the height and backed away until he bumped his head on the feline's chest.

— Look carefully. — she said, keeping her gaze fixed on the field below.

Isaac turned his face and approached the edge to get a better view, and that's when he saw a whole flock of vaelions scattered across the field.

— That's amazing! I've never seen so many of them together in one place. — Isaac said, open-mouthed.

— The leader was aggressive because there are many newborn cubs in the herd. — the feline reported, wrapping her tail around Isaac's waist to prevent him from falling off the edge.

Isaac sighed, letting his smile fade slowly. He settled himself cross-legged and began to observe.

— Thalara… — he called to her, breaking the silence when it became unbearable. — Why didn't you return to the stars?

The feline sighed, letting out a brief chuckle. — You asked a good question, cub. — she laughed briefly. — The truth is, I got tired of being up there. — she explained. — When I was younger, it was an exciting and honorable duty. But it's only when you grow up that you start to see the truth. And after everything that happened to me, I thought about giving up countless times.

Isaac rolled his eyes around the place, curious, until he spotted the large vaelion that had attacked him earlier circling the group, keeping its distance while monitoring the area.

— But then I saw the other side of the story and understood. This was my destiny. Everything that happened had to happen… so that I could meet *you*.

Isaac blinked, adjusted his eyebrows, and stared at the feline. — Me?

— Yes, Isaac. It wasn't my destiny to have a great lineage. My destiny was to find you and help you! — she said, smiling with her eyes, and then licked his face. Isaac laughed for a moment, running his hand through his spiky brown hair. — I learned that the best way to understand humans was to walk among them.

And here I am... and for the first time in a long time, I'm happy! — Thalara looked up, and this time Isaac saw no sadness in the feline's gaze, only longing and acceptance.

Isaac raised his head and leaned against the feline's chest, allowing a smile to appear on his face and a sigh to escape from his nostrils.

Although they still had a few hours to go before reaching the castle, Isaac no longer felt sad or guilty about what had happened; on the contrary, he felt happy.

~ December 24, Bright Moon Castle ~

As soon as they returned to the castle, the princesses anticipated the explanation of the new plan for Adora and Bow. After the storm, Entrapta, still in Plumeria, managed to repair the tower's signal, and all the computers responsible for mapping Etheria were back in operation.

— All right, let's review what we have. — Glimmer began, tapping the screen and changing the background to display the map. — It was on this trail that Mila last saw Isaac before he disappeared. — the queen pointed out. — If the storm caught Isaac here, it's likely that it took him off the trail.

Everyone was focused on the screen when something caught Mermista's interest.

— What if the storm took Isaac to the mountain? — she asked, suddenly standing up before marking three regions on the map. — We've observed an aggressive druvok in these regions. If Isaac is somewhere in these areas, we need to find him quickly. — Mermista switched to another map, displaying an image of a large druvok prowling the mountains.

Everyone in the room tensed up when they saw the image of the druvok. A large beast with a short temper. That's how everyone who had ever crossed its path knew it. Adora, who had already

faced one, knew that fighting ancient beasts was an arduous challenge.

The blonde looked at Catra, holding her wife's hand and bringing it to her lips. Catra said nothing, just tried to push away negative thoughts as she caressed her belly.

— Let's take the ships and fly over as much territory as possible. The storm has subsided, but Entrapta said another one could occur and take us by surprise. So we need to act fast. — warned Netossa.

With the new plan in place, everyone left the meeting room and headed for the exit. Catra was surrounded by children watching the soldiers and princesses prepare.

Not far away, they had no idea that Isaac was already on his way. And not just him.

The wind no longer howled with the same fury. The snow began to settle, heavy and silent, as if the world were holding its breath.

When he caught sight of the castle, Isaac let out a sigh of joy and excitement. He smiled broadly, eager to reunite with his family.

— This is where we part ways, little one. — Thalara refreshed his memory, sitting down and watching the little boy's back intently.

Isaac turned slowly, his gaze downcast. — I don't like goodbyes…

Thalara smiled subtly, leaning close to Isaac and licking his forehead. — Want to hear a secret? — she asked, and he agreed. — I don't like goodbyes either! — she declared, letting out a muffled giggle.

Isaac smiled, even though his eyes were filled with tears. — Will I see you again? — he asked.

Thalara sighed and caressed his face with her tail. — Wherever you go, I will always be with you. Even if you can't see me… *Feel*

me! — replied Thalara.

The big cat pulled him closer, touching their foreheads together. Isaac raised his hands and touched her face, and they both closed their eyes.

— May the light accompany your days, and may the stars guard your nights. May the water give you strength, and the earth give you shelter. Now go, cub… your family awaits you. — she said.

Isaac began to gradually distance himself, losing the sensation of Thalara's soft touch. She looked at him, blinking slowly, and nodded her head.

Isaac took a deep breath, letting the air out through his mouth. A tear rolled down his cheek, but this time Isaac didn't wipe it away. He just smiled tenderly and turned, running toward the castle. Seeing that everyone was gathered at the entrance, he picked up his pace.

— Mom! — the little boy shouted, alerting everyone to his presence.

Adora stepped away from the ship, lifted her face, and turned around. — Isaac? — Her voice failed her. Seeing her son running toward her, her heart raced, and she could only run toward him as well. — Isaac! — Adora cried, tears of relief streaming down her face as she opened her arms to welcome the little boy. But suddenly she stopped. — NO! — Her cry was not fast enough to prevent the little boy from dodging the attack of the huge beast.

The Druvok grabbed him, using its enormous claws to pin him to the ground. Isaac couldn't scream, terrified and at the same time perplexed as he identified the scar on the creature's face.

— It's you… — Isaac whispered, his eyes even wider.

— Hey! Stay away from my son! — Adora brandished her sword, assuming her form as She-Ra, and advanced toward the enormous beast.

The Druvok opened its mouth, greeting the blonde with flames, causing her to retreat and use her shield to protect herself. In doing so, Adora did not notice the Druvok approaching and was surprised by a side attack that pulled her away from Isaac.

The soldiers advanced, attacking the creature with shots and spears. However, while Isaac tried to get out of the mess, the Druvok captured him once again.

The great beast lifted him up, and one of the arrows grazed Isaac's arm, causing him to cry out in pain.

— Stop! — exclaimed Catra, holding her other children back so they wouldn't run toward the danger. — He's using Isaac as a shield!

The soldiers looked at each other, confused, and even the princesses were forced to retreat.

— Now what? — asked Bow, keeping his arrow pointed at the beast, but unable to act while the creature held Isaac in front of its body.

Adora spat blood from her mouth, made her sword reappear, and walked back in front of the soldiers. The ice on the ground made everything even more difficult.

Druvok threw more fireballs at the soldiers and the castle, forcing the princesses to retreat further and use their powers to protect their children, dragging them away as fragments of the castle collapsed and were consumed by the flames.

Scorpia and Bow advanced once more, but Druvok anticipated their actions. Adora had to step in front of them, raising a shining shield to defend them as fireballs cut through the air.

Suddenly, Glimmer appeared behind the creature and struck it with magic. The crash made the beast roar, and in a fit of rage, it threw Isaac far away.

The little boy rolled through the snow until his back collided with a rock. Adora broke her shield and ran toward her son.

— Isaac! — exclaimed the blonde, trying to reach him, but a new burst of fire prevented her from advancing. — Bow! Mermista! Take that thing down!

Bow fired explosive arrows at the ice, breaking it, and Mermista used water to fire powerful jets at the Druvok.

With impressive agility, the creature dodged and, in a sudden movement, tore out a tree trunk and threw it at the princess. With no time to react, Mermista was hit and fell on top of the soldiers.

Druvok let out a deafening roar, causing everyone to cover their ears in pain. Suddenly, he stopped, raised his head, and began to sniff the air.

Adora frowned, and that's when she looked away and saw Isaac with blood on his head.

— No...! — She ran, but the Druvok was fast. When he reached the blonde, he opened his jaws and bit her leg, throwing her onto the thin ice.

The soldiers continued shooting at him, but now their focus was no longer on the other people. The Druvok changed direction, heading towards Isaac.

The little prince fainted when he hit the rock. Opening his eyes with difficulty, he found himself face to face with the Druvok's sharp teeth.

The beast rose, attacking the little one with its huge paw and pinning him against the rock, opening its mouth wider and wider. The beast's saliva dripped onto Isaac's face as it bent down to grab his head. Isaac couldn't hold back his scream.

— **MOM!**

Chapter 8: I will never forget

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

{...}

— **MOM!** — Isaac's voice sounded shaky, piercing the frozen air.

Just when Adora and Catra thought they were going to lose their cub, a shadow leaped onto the rock, grabbing the druvok, who rolled through the snow.

— Thalara! — Isaac exclaimed, recognizing the feline, his eyes wide and filled with tears.

Thalara struck the druvok's face, knocking out one of its teeth, then returned to Isaac, standing in front of the little boy.

— Isaac, you need to get out of here! — she shouted, grabbing Isaac by the collar and throwing him toward Adora.

Despite her injured leg, the blonde ran fast, jumped high, and managed to catch her son before he hit the ground.

Abruptly, the air changed completely. Without the snowstorm, everyone could see firsthand the beginning of a fierce battle between two powerful beasts.

Thalara and Druvok walked slowly in circles, roaring at each other. When Druvok tried to advance on the people, Thalara lunged forward, raised her paws, and struck him several times with her sharp claws in a brutal manner.

The druvok backed away enough to unleash its flames, but Thalara was quicker. Using her fur to camouflage herself, she attacked the beast from behind and sank her teeth into it.

Everyone stayed at a safe distance; even so, the princesses and soldiers kept their weapons raised, ready to retaliate if the beast tried anything.

The battle continued — the druvok struck Thalara's face with its paw, scratching her and causing blood to flow, yet the feline remained standing. She circled the beast, which roared louder and louder, attacking it whenever she had the chance and striking it with her claws, causing its black blood to spurt onto the white snow.

Once again, they began to circle each other, glaring fiercely as their voices shook the ground and darkened the sky.

Isaac swallowed hard, watching the fight with a heavy heart. He wanted to run to Thalara, but Adora held him back, holding him tightly in her arms.

The druvok stood up on two legs, rising menacingly and frightening everyone with its fearsome size.

Thalara roared and lunged forward, rearing up on her hind legs and sinking her teeth into his arms. The druvok opened its mouth and fired fireballs at the feline, but she let go in time and managed to escape.

— Mom, you have to help her! — Isaac shouted, struggling to escape the blonde woman's grip.

As soon as they heard the sharp, shrill sound of the druvok, the ground shook again and dry lightning streaked across the sky.

Thalara seized her opportunity, sinking her large fangs into the druvok's skin, causing blood to spurt from the creature's neck. The druvok's large paws fell, and its once brutal and threatening body went limp, collapsing to the ground when Thalara let go.

The feline lowered her paws, positioning part of her body over the imposing Druvok, and stared at everyone, opening her mouth to let her voice echo.

When silence fell, Mermista began to look at the soldiers and the other princesses, being the first to ask: — So… is it over?

They watched the large feline move away from Druvok's body and slowly approach Isaac.

The little boy tried again to move away from his mother, but Adora and Catra were still hesitant to allow their son to approach such a large animal, one that had just killed an even larger one.

The feline stopped when she noticed the two women's posture, and they stared at each other intently.

Catra tilted her head slightly, curious about the creature, and felt a chill run down her spine. Catra heard a voice when her eyes met those of the feline.

— Thalara! — Isaac suddenly exclaimed, causing her to look back. However, she wasn't quick enough to escape the druvok's teeth, which grabbed her neck and threw her into the air, slamming her body against the ice.

Adora widened her eyes, pulled Isaac back, and handed him to Catra, while the guards surrounded the beast.

Now weaker, Netossa used her nets to knock the druvok to the ground, even though it was still trying to get up. The guards surrounded it, planting their spears in the ground with the tips pointed at the animal, and pulled the ropes.

Glimmer used magic to lasso a magical rope around his neck, sealing his mouth at the same time, causing him to lie on his back.

Adora approached them with her shining sword in hand. Standing face to face with the creature, she mounted it and aimed at its chest. The blonde drove the sword as deep as she could until, finally, the monstrous druvok stopped breathing.

Once again, silence was accompanied by a cold wind whispering through the trees. Bow and Scorpia removed the ropes from the animal, observing only the inert body of the enormous creature, its blood dripping onto the ground; a truly terrifying scene.

Adora drew her sword and, with a quick movement, wiped all the blood from it. She went to Catra, wrapping her wife and children in an embrace. However, when she tried to hug Isaac, the boy broke free from Mila's hands and ran away. Although part of his legs sank into the thick snow, he continued until he reached Thalara's body.

— Thalara! — he shouted, shaking the feline's body repeatedly. — Thalara! Please get up! — he insisted, as tears streamed down his face, blurring his vision. Isaac held the feline's head, caressing her face as his cries reverberated in the air.

Mila and Finn helped Catra make her way to the little one. Adora also accompanied them, being the only one who remained closest to the feline's body. The blonde was paralyzed when she saw her son raise his head, his eyes sunken and his voice hoarse from crying so much, holding the creature as if it were his own life.

And maybe… it really was.

— Please… Save her! Please! — He sobbed loudly, bending forward and burying his face in the cat's fur, letting the tears flow as he called her name. — Please… *Mom…* wake up!

The silence had never been so deafening as it was at that moment, interrupted only by the young prince's cries and clamor.

Adora crouched down beside them, observing the cat's body. She took a deep breath, returning to her form as She-Ra, and reached out her hand over her, touching the soft, cold fur as she closed her eyes.

The princesses, soldiers, and even servants of the castle joined hands, forming a large circle around the three.

While Bow and Glimmer supported Catra, the woman and her daughters rested their hands on the blonde's back.

Adora squeezed her eyes shut, and her power intensified even more, until it finally illuminated the feline's body. Isaac, still holding tightly to Thalara, stepped back a little and looked around.

The princesses also closed their eyes, allowing their powers to manifest. They glowed intensely, becoming one.

Isaac wrapped Thalara in a new embrace, closing his eyes tighter and whispering:

— Mother, please… come back!

The immense glow that illuminated half the kingdom could be seen from the ships in space, becoming so powerful that it took a few minutes to dissipate.

The dark clouds that had previously covered the sky opened up, allowing the sun to shine through. The castle was no longer on fire, and the snow on the ground had become whiter and brighter.

Adora only opened her eyes when quiet returned to the place, and she felt the warmth of her wife's hand on her shoulder. The blonde got up carefully, being embraced by her other children.

They all looked at each other, relieved, but the anguish still remained. There was no action. There was no indication that it had worked. Thalara did not open her eyes.

Isaac slowly raised his head, sniffling, and looked at his mothers. The little boy couldn't hold back his tears, and when he saw Catra reach out her hand, he immediately ran into her arms.

Mila, Finn, and Ember also embraced them, tearfully sharing their brother's pain, but also the joy of his return. Adora didn't hesitate to join them, enveloping the whole family in an embrace while stroking Isaac's head.

— I heard you, little one…

Isaac's eyes widened, gasping. He distanced himself from his family and turned to Thalara lying in the snow.

Everyone was surprised to see the feline's tail move slowly, heavily — alive. Then she turned her head to Isaac, smiling with her eyes.

— Thalara! — Isaac shouted, smiling broadly. He jumped on top of the feline, who grabbed him and hugged him tightly, warming his previously cold body.

— Haha, it's great to see you too, cub! — said the feline, as she rolled in the snow with the prince and the two laughed together.

Adora and the others sighed, and this time, the fear had truly disappeared.

After all the stress of battle, everyone hugged each other in celebration. While the soldiers took care of the druvok, the princesses remained gathered around the great feline.

She rose slowly, and although Isaac didn't have enough strength to support her, he helped her anyway.

— Careful… — Isaac warned, holding the feline's arm, noticing her muscles tense with the effort.

When she managed to stand up completely, the children were amazed, admiring the feline's gracefulness.

— That… — Jasper began.

— It's… — Arrow murmured as well.

— Awesome! — everyone exclaimed in unison, making Isaac and Thalara smile.

As a result, all the children began to surround the cat, asking questions. However, they couldn't understand her, and Isaac had

to be the translator.

One moment they were with the cat; the next, it was Isaac who was surrounded by his friends.

Arrow and Jack jumped on him, hugging him tightly and celebrating with laughter and tears the fact that he had returned home.

While the children teased Isaac, Adora and Catra stood facing the cat.

— You saved my son. — the blonde began, glancing quickly at the little boy. — I have no words to describe my gratitude. Thank you so, so much! — Adora knelt, bowing her head, and the other princesses did the same.

Thalara simply closed her eyes for a second and nodded. She focused her attention on Catra, surprising her by leaving her spot and starting to sniff her.

— I know you. — Thalara said, sitting back down.

Catra raised her eyebrows slightly, shocked. — What do you mean, you know me? — she asked, analyzing the feline's serene expression. Adora looked at the two of them, not understanding anything.

— Can you talk to her? — asked the blonde.

— Yes, I can… — she replied, approaching Thalara and reaching out to touch her. However, she hesitated and backed away. Realizing the woman's intention, Thalara leaned in and allowed Catra to touch her. — How do you know me?

— Not exactly you. But rather the world your ancestors inhabited. — When I first saw Isaac, I was sure he carried the blood of the Magicats. — said the big feline, and both began to watch the little boy playing with his friends.

Thalara also glanced at Finn, Mila, and Ember, letting out a deep sigh. They were exactly as he had seen them in his visions, and his heart beat faster.

— I'm really glad to know that the new generation of Magicats is being well cared for. — she said, looking back at Catra. The woman didn't know how to respond, so she just looked away and smiled.

Adora, who was just watching, let a smile appear on her face, knowing that Catra would keep those words in her heart, even if she didn't show it.

At that moment, Thalara's ears moved forward as she heard the baby's sounds, and she brought her face even closer to Catra's belly.

Adora held her wife's shoulders, feeling a little tense at the feline's sudden approach. However, Catra didn't comment on it and remained silent.

— My wife already said it, but we really can't thank you enough for everything you've done. — Catra resumed the conversation.

— Actually, I think I'm the one who should be thanking you. — she replied, raising her head again and looking at Isaac. — Your son is truly an extraordinary boy. He has brightened my path more than I could have imagined. That's why… I'm so happy to see him happy!

Before he could say anything else, Isaac and Ember jumped on Adora's back, causing the blonde to lose her balance and fall into the snow. Even Mila and Finn joined them, falling on top of the blonde.

Isaac was the first to get up, walking over to Thalara and hugging her. The feline returned the gesture, wrapping her tail around the little boy and licking him a few times, touching their foreheads together.

Catra could see the magic that united them at that moment. It was so intense and genuine that not even time would dare to break it.

He distanced himself and went to Catra, wrapping her in a hug as well. Suddenly, the young prince was surprised to feel a slight kick coming from his mother's belly. He moved his face away, but left his hand on her belly, feeling the kicks of his future sibling.

— We all miss you so much, my baby! — Catra declared, beginning to sob as she hugged the little one again and allowed the tears to fall once more.

Mila and Finn joined the embrace, calling for Adora, whose eyes were covered by little Ember. The blonde managed to reach her family and, after hugging them, removed her daughter's hand from her face and called Thalara.

— You're part of the family too. — Adora affirmed.

The feline tilted her head slightly and left her spot. She walked over to them and joined the family hug. As they enjoyed the moment, a ship flew over the castle, landing at the entrance, and when the doors opened, everyone was surprised by the presence of King Micah, Queen Castaspella, and Amity — daughter of Netossa and Spinnerella.

— I believe we've missed a lot. — said King Micah, holding a bowl of his special lasagna.

~ In Plumeria, December 24 – 10:30 p.m. ~

Adora wasn't sure what to expect when she returned to Plumeria. When they left the kingdom, everything was in a real mess.

However, as they walked along the path, they all passed under a flowery arch adorned with colorful lights. When they reached the center of the party, everyone was speechless.

— Welcome to the Christmas party! — Perfuma, Spinnerella, and Entrapta said together.

All the space that had been destroyed by fire and water had been renovated, and new things had been put in place.

A new tree was set up, this time with a delicate scent and a huge star at the top. Next to it, the band hired by Glimmer played traditional Christmas songs from Etheria.

The tables were set and stocked with food, and Mermista couldn't contain her excitement when she saw her dragon-shaped chocolate sculpture there too.

Frosta used a snow cannon to attract the children, introducing them to the playground that had been restored and now featured new toys.

The inhabitants of Plumeria welcomed Thalara with acclamation. Not even the feline was immune to being adorned with a flower necklace and a Christmas hat.

Adora gave a meaningful look to Entrapta, who had replaced the lights that had paralyzed half the people.

— Relax! This time, no one will be hypnotized. — she assured her with a broad smile as she took a sip of her favorite drink.

The blonde rolled her eyes, shook her head slightly, and let out a sigh followed by a giggle as she walked with Catra toward one of the tables.

Sitting near the huge tree, they observed everything around them. After all the chaos that had ensued, peace and fun finally prevailed. Now with a very special guest.

Thalara moved among the people, attracting everyone's attention, but that didn't bother her; on the contrary, it made her even happier.

The music grew louder, the children ran back and forth, and the older ones enjoyed themselves dancing and savoring Christmas dinner.

Catra caressed her belly, resting her head on the blonde's shoulder, while she tasted Mermista's special dish.

— Wow… I think Mermista has won. This food is incredible! — exclaimed Adora, babbling with her mouth full, making Catra laugh and grab a napkin to wipe her face.

Adora sighed, watching Catra take some of the food to try, frown, and let out a moan of satisfaction. The blonde smiled, but soon her lips lost their affectionate expression. She looked away, breathing heavily.

— I'm sorry… — she said suddenly.

Catra looked at her, confused. — Why are you apologizing? — she asked gently, her heterochromatic eyes searching for her wife's cyan blue ones.

— It's just that… — She let out a deep sigh, raising her head and looking at everyone. — I was so focused on giving you the perfect Christmas that I didn't realize I was the one ruining everything.

Catra remained silent, allowing her wife to express her hurt feelings. She reflected for a moment, looking away from the blonde and observing the other people at the party.

— You're right. It wasn't perfect. — she said dryly, making Adora even more depressed. — It was more than perfect!

The blonde's eyes widened, showing her surprise as she looked at the woman beside her. — What? — she asked in a whisper.

— It wasn't perfect, but it was exactly as I expected. I mean, I didn't expect our son to get lost in the snow and come back with a third mother. — Catra laughed, showing her fangs, and the two watched the young prince riding on the back of the huge feline.

Then Catra fixed her eyes on the blonde next to her. — You really tried hard, but you went a little overboard with this perfect Christmas story. But, Adora, look around!

Catra took her wife's face in her hands and made her look at everyone again. Adora pressed her lips together and exhaled slowly. Despite all the confusion that had occurred, they continued smiling, singing, dancing, and loving.

— What's the fun in being perfect? — Catra recited calmly. — It's in imperfection that we learn from each other, Adora. No matter how hard we try to always get it right, it won't always be possible. And guess what? That's okay! — she exclaimed, letting out a half-laugh through her nose.

Adora smiled thoughtfully. Then, the blonde was taken by surprise again when Catra placed a gift box in her lap.

— Is this for me? — asked the blonde, looking between her wife and the box. The feline woman nodded as Adora pulled the bow on the box and opened it carefully. When she removed the lid, her eyes filled with tears.

— Congratulations, Mom. You got it right. — Catra said, stroking her wife's back as she processed the situation.

— Wait… wh-what…? — the blonde stammered, shedding a tear as she pulled out a pair of small red shoes with a knitted flower on top. — You did this? — Adora asked.

— Yes… I know we decided to wait until the day of delivery to find out the baby's gender, but I wanted to surprise you. — Catra said, kissing the blonde on the cheek and wiping her face. — It's a girl! — Catra whispered, smiling and with tears in her eyes.

Adora cried a little more, unable to take her eyes off the gift. — It's so beautiful. Thank you for the surprise. I'm really surprised! This is the best gift in the world! — she exclaimed enthusiastically, and the two laughed. Adora left the box on the table, pulled Catra into a tight hug, and sealed her lips with a kiss.

~ December 24, 11:45 p.m. ~

The party was going smoothly, and the moment to set off the fireworks was approaching. And no one was more excited to see the sky lit up by colorful fireworks than Isaac.

While some people danced and sang, others occupied the tables. Glimmer, Perfuma, and Mermista took the place of the band's lead singer and started singing all the songs — visibly already drunk.

While Ember slept leaning on his arm, Catra noticed something that almost made her spit out her food. She controlled herself and wiped the corner of her mouth, reaching for the blonde's shirt and pulling it.

— What is it? Do you want more lasagna? — Adora asked, turning to her wife.

— No, look over there! — she pointed with her head, and as she looked the other way, the blonde's lips parted and her jaw dropped.

Finn and Flora… kissing!

Adora's shoulders slumped and her eyes widened. It took her a moment to process, shaking her head quickly and looking for her other daughter.

While talking with friends, Mila was sitting on Sam's lap, immersed in her own world.

Adora sighed deeply, sitting back down in the chair next to Catra. She banged her head on the table and muttered phrases like, "I still remember when Finn learned to walk" and "Mila always woke me up by jumping on the bed when we went to explore the forest.

Catra stroked her wife's back in a gesture of comfort, but couldn't hold back a discreet laugh. She smiled as she looked back at her children.

...

Isaac looked for Thalara and found her near the exit. He ran to her, stopped, and began to approach her quietly.

— You'll need more than that to surprise me, cub. — she said suddenly, taking Isaac by surprise.

— Oh, that's not fair! — he protested, climbing on her back, grabbing her head, and leaning forward. — Thalara, why are you here? The party isn't over yet.

Isaac slipped and fell forward, but was caught by the feline's large paw, which gently placed him on the ground.

— It's time for me to go, little one.

— What?! — he exclaimed. — But why? Did I do something wrong? — Isaac asked nervously.

— Not at all, little one. I've done what I had to do here. — She pulled him close with her paw. — My mission was to take you back to your family. Now I must continue my journey. — said Thalara, rubbing her snout against his face.

Isaac looked down, his eyes downcast. Thalara let out a soft, brief laugh as she lifted the little boy's face with her tail.

— Don't make that face, puppy. Everything in life has a beginning, middle, and end. — she said. — But just because I'm leaving doesn't mean I'll forget you.

— Promise? — he asked, his eyes shining.

— In all my life, I've never met a cub so brave, determined, a little stubborn… — She looked at him with a raised eyebrow, making him shrug his shoulders, feigning innocence. — But also as loving and generous as you are. — she said, wiping away the little one's tears, which he no longer hid. — I will never forget you, my cub.

Isaac sniffed, with a broad smile, stretched out his arms, and wrapped them around the feline's head. — I love you, Thalara!

— I love you too, cub! — she replied, wrapping her large paw and tail around Isaac's body.

The imposing feline slowly backed away, taking a few steps backward, and looked directly at the young prince. Isaac wiped his face with his forearm and smiled broadly.

— Goodbye, Thalara.

— Goodbye, no, Isaac. See you later! — The feline sighed deeply, turning slowly and walking out of the place, with Isaac following her with his eyes the whole time.

As soon as the feline disappeared from view, Isaac returned to the party and found Mila and Finn waiting for him.

— Why did she leave? — Finn was the first to ask.

— She had other things to do. But she'll be back next Christmas! — he assured them, a radiant smile still on his face. In a surprising and unusual gesture, Mila grabbed the little boy and hugged him tightly.

— I'm sorry, I promise I won't lose you again. Never again! — she said, her voice slightly choked up as she tried to hold back her tears.

Isaac rolled his eyes, smiling, and patted his older sister on the back. — It's okay. I promise to be more attentive, too. — he replied, breaking free from his sister's embrace and being hugged by Finn instead.

— You gave us quite a scare! — Finn grabbed the youngest's neck and ruffled his hair.

— I bet you didn't even miss me. — Isaac broke away from Finn, fixing his messy hair.

Mila sighed and crossed her arms. — That's not true. Ember missed you a lot.

— Ember just missed picking on me. — Isaac said.

— That's not true!

— Ah! — Isaac jumped high, landing in Finn's lap as the three of them looked at little Ember with mischievous expressions. — See? I said so!

Ember laughed, waiting for Isaac to get down so she could hug him. When they separated, Ember kicked Isaac in the shin and ran off, clearly teasing him, and it worked. They took off, leaving their two older brothers behind. Although it seemed violent, this was how the two showed their love.

Mila walked beside Finn, watching her sister out of the corner of her eye, but he noticed immediately.

— What?

— You and Flora, huh? — she laughed mischievously. — So, is that date happening or not? — she asked with a raised eyebrow, and Finn knew she would insist on the subject if he didn't tell the truth.

Finn sighed deeply, smiled subtly, and her cheeks flushed slightly.

— Yes, we're going on a date. — she admitted, running her hand through her hair without looking at Mila. Her older sister laughed, patted her younger sister on the back, and congratulated her.

There were only seconds left before the fireworks started. Everyone took their places, standing with friends or family. Catra intertwined her fingers with the blonde's, smiling and kissing her.

Mila returned to Sam's side, wrapping him in a hug. Finn did the same and went to Flora and Miranda, already looking up at the sky.

Ember, who was still running away from her brother, stopped and looked where her aunt Entrapta was calling her. — Isaac, it's time! — Ember warned.

5

Glimmer hugged Bow and stole a kiss from him. Her children rolled their eyes and made expressions of disdain. This only made the queen kiss Bow again, amused by her children's reactions.

4

Hordak grabbed Ember and placed her on his head, walking over to Perfuma and Scorpia.

Mermista, Sea Hawk, Frosta, Swift Wind, and Melog were also standing near them, their ears protected because of their sensitive hearing. However, the feline would not miss watching the light show in the sky.

3

Entrapta placed Isaac on a chair, adjusting its height so he could help her.

— Ready, Isaac? — she asked excitedly.

2

Isaac raised his arm, opened his hand wide, smiled bigger than his face, and with all his might, threw his arm down.

— Orange button!

The end.

Chapter End Notes

That's it! We've reached the end of the fic.
I hope you enjoyed it. I had a lot of fun writing this fic, which was supposed to be a quick project at first, but it touched my heart and I didn't want to stop writing.
However, as our wise Thalara said, everything has an end.

I'll post an extra, concluding an important question in the story. But the rest of the extras (which I believe will only be two) will be posted on my Ko-fi in a few days. I'm going to take this time to breathe a little and organize the other fanfics.

Anyway, that's it for today.
I'll be back!

Chapter 9: Epilogue — The Mystery of the Gifts & the First Cry

Chapter Notes

Now it's finally over!
I'm already editing all the chapters and extras to post on my Ko-fi, so stay tuned.
If you can help me by sharing or buying me a coffee, that would be wonderful!
That's all for today. See you in my other fics! <3

{...}

Another day began in the kingdom of Grayskull. Adora was with her wife and children outside the castle, enjoying a family breakfast.

Catra was in the last stages of pregnancy, but apparently the baby refused to come out — which resulted in a lot of grumbling in pain from the feline woman.

Adora read some letters while the children enjoyed the sunny morning and the remaining snow to have fun. Catra sipped a glass of milk, but barely touched the food on the table, as she was still in pain.

Suddenly, she looked up and smiled, forgetting her discomfort for a moment when she saw Ember chasing Isaac with a bat.

— Honey... — Catra nudged the blonde's arm with a spoon.

— Yes?

— Look. — Catra nodded, and when the blonde turned her face, as did Mila and Finn, they couldn't contain their laughter when Isaac climbed a tree branch to escape Ember.

While Mila talked about Isaac becoming faster at running to escape the youngest member of the family, Adora let out a long sigh.

Catra rolled her eyes, amused, but she needed to intervene before they really hurt themselves.

— Ember, your brother is not a piñata! Put that down! — she exclaimed, giving her daughter a stern look, who simply rested the bat on her shoulder and returned to the table with downcast eyes. However, as soon as she saw her favorite food on the table, she smiled again.

Isaac ran his hand over his face and sighed with relief, but when he took one hand off the branch, he lost his strength and fell into the snow.

Adora let out a soft laugh, looking at Catra. — Ember takes after you. When we were kids, you always went overboard when playing. — said the blonde, putting the cards aside.

Catra let out a short snort. — You who couldn't take a beating.

— OHHHHH! — Mila exclaimed, laughing at her mother, while Finn tapped his index fingers on the table, intensifying the teasing.

— Ha, ha! That's right. Go ahead and laugh! — the blonde said, pouting. Suddenly, Mila rested her arms on the table and focused her gaze on her mother's belly.

— Shouldn't the baby have been born by now? Christmas has come and gone, and there's still no sign of him. — she commented.

— Mom, when you were pregnant with us, did it take this long too? — Finn joined the conversation.

Catra looked down at her belly, running her hand over it. — With Mila, it was quick. She was born before her due date. — she replied to the woman. — The same thing happened with Isaac.

— Finn was born three days after his due date, and Ember was born just two days later. — Adora recalled, looking at each of her children. Then, with a tense expression, she looked at her wife's belly. — But it's been six days and nothing has happened.

They began to reflect, as a thousand different thoughts ran through the minds of everyone at the table.

— We'd better check it out. — Catra said, breaking the tense silence that had settled over them.

Adora nodded. — I'll call Perfuma and Spinnerella. — replied the blonde, pushing her chair back and heading toward the interior of the castle.

— Adora! — Glimmer shouted, suddenly appearing in front of the blonde before she could reach the door.

— AH! — The blonde was startled and, reflexively, punched her sister in the face.

— OW! F***! What the hell is this?! — The queen began to scream as she rubbed the affected area.

— Are you crazy?! Why did you suddenly appear?! Are you trying to scare me to death?!

Catra was annoyed by all the noise that followed, disrupting her peaceful morning.

— Shut up! — she yelled, staring at the two queens.

— B-B-But she was the one who—! — Adora stammered, pointing accusingly at Glimmer, but stopped when Catra frowned and gave them a deadly look.

Both queens, defeated, lowered their heads and walked back to the table.

Mila tapped Finn's leg lightly, getting his attention. — Mom is amazing. She managed to tame them both in no time.

— No wonder, she was captain of an enemy empire. — They nodded simultaneously, watching Catra control her wife and sister-in-law.

— Why did you come here, Auntie? — Isaac asked, settling at the table after recovering from his fall.

Glimmer raised her head once more and snapped her fingers. — Presents!

While the queen kept a broad smile on her face, everyone stared at her in bewilderment.

— Presents? — Adora broke the silence. — Are you referring to the missing presents? — asked the blonde.

— Yes!

— What?! — the children exclaimed in unison.

— You found the gifts? — Mila asked, rising from her chair.

— Where? — Isaac also rose from the table. Finn, Ember, and Catra followed close behind him.

The queen cleared her throat. — It will be easier if I show you. — she said, taking her nephews by the hand. — Will you two meet us at the castle? — she questioned, without waiting for an answer, and teleported herself and the children to Bright Moon.

Adora and Catra boarded the ship and quickly arrived at Bright Moon. As soon as they carefully disembarked, Glimmer was already waiting for them at the entrance.

The three headed toward a part of the garden that connected to the forest. Among some trees with large roots, buried in the snow, were all the missing Christmas presents.

— What is this?! — Adora gasped, putting her hand to her head in astonishment.

Soldiers and children alike were helping to dig up the missing gifts. Catra and Adora were speechless, just watching the scene in amazement.

Suddenly, Isaac appeared from the huge hole with a gift and ran toward his mothers.

— Look! Look! This one's for me! — he exclaimed excitedly, showing off the neatly wrapped package.

— Really, sweetheart? Who gave it to you? — Catra asked, smiling at her son's excitement.

— I don't know… — he replied, turning the wrapped package until he found a label. — Oh, I found it! It says… from Ember to Isaac?

The family and soldiers stared at little Ember, even more surprised.

— Is this serious? — Mila asked, looking at Finn, but her brother just shrugged.

— Yes, it's true. — Ember replied simply, her hands clasped behind her back. — But it's not just for you, Isaac. It's for Jack and Arrow, too. I made it *especially* for you guys.

Immediately, the two friends gathered around Isaac, thanking Ember for the gift. However, the youngest girl's broad smile and mischievous look made the others wonder if this was a good idea.

— She's up to something... — Adora whispered in her wife's ear, who nodded slightly as they watched the three princes hastily tear open the wrapping.

As soon as they removed the lid from the box, a huge clown jumped out.

— HA! — they shouted, dropping the box on the floor before running away.

While the adults watched her with raised eyebrows, Ember laughed loudly, holding her stomach. As soon as she stopped laughing, she turned to the mothers and just shrugged, resuming digging through the snow in search of her gift, as if nothing had happened.

— Yes, she's just like you when we were kids. — Adora commented, letting out an amused sigh.

The more they dug, the more gifts appeared. With excitement growing, Queen Glimmer teleported from kingdom to kingdom, bringing the other princesses and their heirs to finally exchange gifts.

Mila stopped digging and pulled another gift out of the snow. — Hey, Finn! This one's for you! — announced her older sister, tossing the package in her direction.

Before opening it, Finn looked at the tag and walked over to their mothers. — Mom… Mila found this. — Finn held up the gift, showing it to Adora.

— Oh, yes! This… this is my gift to you. — said the blonde woman, fiddling with her shirt collar.

Catra was aware that his wife only acted like this when she was nervous. It was a habit the blonde woman had developed whenever she had to give gifts to their children, fearing they would not like them, but in the end everything always turned out fine.

— Can I open it? — asked Finn, and his mother nodded.

Adora swallowed hard, trying not to show her panic, as the young girl used her sharp claws to open the package.

Finn stood still for a moment, staring at the box, when he finally managed to see what was inside.

Catra and Adora looked at each other. The feline woman tapped the blonde and, with a nod, motioned for her to approach the cub.

— So… do you like it? — asked the blonde.

Finn put her hands in the box and slowly stood up, revealing her gift.

— This… This is amazing! — Finn exclaimed, her eyes shining, completely enchanted by the black leather jacket. — Is it really for me?

Adora sighed deeply, allowing her shoulders to relax. — Yes, I bought it for you, Finn. — she affirmed, extending her arms when Finn jumped toward her and wrapped her in a tight hug.

— Thank you, thank you, thank you! — she said enthusiastically, breaking free from her mother's arms and running toward her sister and friends to show off her gift.

The blonde returned to her wife's side, sighing with relief and smiling. Catra just rolled her eyes amusedly, aware that her wife always exaggerated when it came to their children.

— I still have one question… — Frosta said suddenly, looking at the huge hole. — Who buried our gifts?

The question hung in the air, and everyone looked at each other with confused expressions, with no idea of the answer.

It was at that moment that Isaac, Arrow, and Jack returned after the scare caused by little Ember. However, they were not alone.

— Mother! Look, the Nyqis are back! — cried the young prince.

Suddenly, a whole group of Nyqis appeared, jumping between the trees and the castle, playing with the children and adults.

One of the Nyqis landed on Adora's shoulder. As she tried to pet the animal, it quickly pulled the wedding ring off her finger and ran away.

— Hey! Come back here, you little thief! — The blonde chased after the animal, stopping when it stopped.

The animal began to dig into the ground, but Adora jumped quickly, grabbing the animal and trying to retrieve the ring. The two entered into a dispute over the ring, but in that simple gesture, everyone realized the truth.

— The Nyqis stole the gifts! — they said in unison, as if it were the most obvious thing in the universe.

— Argh! Of course, it was them. — Swift Wind snorted. — Those little pests love to steal and hide other people's things. — said the alicorn, with a very dissatisfied expression. He, too, had been a victim of the Nyqis' mischief, as had many others.

With the mystery solved, everyone picked up the gifts that were now unearthed. Then they began to hand them to each other, as they should have done long ago.

Perfuma stood next to Catra, watching eagerly as the feline woman unwrapped her gift. Jasper suddenly walked past them and looked at the floor, tilting her head slightly, intrigued.

— Auntie, Catra. — she called, and when she got the two women's attention, she pointed under Catra's chair. — Did you pee?

The older women raised their eyebrows, and when Catra leaned down slightly to investigate, she and Perfuma exchanged astonished glances.

— Oh my God! It's time! — Perfuma exclaimed, alerting everyone.

Adora abandoned the animal that had stolen her ring and ran to her wife sitting in the chair. A stretcher arrived quickly, and Adora

placed Catra on it.

Everyone went to the medical wing, and before entering, Adora turned to her children and kissed each one on the forehead. She took a deep breath and entered the room.

The doors closed with a loud bang, and from that moment on, nothing more was known about Catra.

~ Bright Moon Castle, 21 hours later ~

Night had fallen, but the tension remained high. All the kingdoms had been informed about Queen Catra, and now they could only wait for further news.

In the hallway outside the delivery room were the princesses and their heirs. Isaac, Jack, and Arrow were attentive to any movement at the door; Finn, Flora, and Jasper were entertaining Ember with a card game, while Mila, Sam, Amity, and Miranda talked with the elders.

Suddenly, the sound of the main door echoed. It opened slowly, and midwives and nurses from the castle came out.

Mila and her siblings stood at the entrance to the room, all four staring at the open door. In every corner of the castle, the muffled cry of a baby could be heard.

Glimmer wiped her face and placed her hands on Mila and Finn's shoulders.

— Go ahead! — said the queen.

The two older sisters exchanged glances and sighed deeply. Then the four heirs entered with hesitant steps, but with hearts full of hope.

The four stopped simultaneously when they came upon the bed where Catra lay. Adora sat in a chair beside her. The blonde stared

at them, tears of happiness streaming down her face, sniffling slightly.

— Come on… come here and meet her! — she invited, waving her hand.

While Isaac and Ember ran into Adora's lap, Mila and Finn went to the other side of the bed.

Ember, being shorter, stood on her tiptoes to try to see her new sister. Seeing her daughter's effort, Adora gently picked her up and placed her next to Catra.

On the other hand, Isaac climbed onto the blonde's back and sat on her shoulders, leaning forward to see his new sister and accidentally blocking his mother's view.

— I can't believe it… — Finn whispered, smiling. Mila touched her mother's dark hair and tucked it behind her ear.

— Are you okay, Mom? — asked her older sister.

— Yes, my love. Much better now. — replied Catra, smiling at her eldest daughter.

Ember approached and looked closely at the newest member of the family. Suddenly, she made a serious expression and looked intently at Catra.

— What's wrong, dear?

— She has no feet or hands! — declared little Ember, causing her mothers to laugh.

Catra explained that the baby was swaddled, which prevented her arms and legs from being seen. So that Ember would no longer be in doubt, Catra pulled the cloths away from the baby a little and showed her.

Ember leaned on her mother's arm and ran her hand over her forehead, letting out a long sigh.

— Phew, what a relief! — she said with a satisfied smile.

The baby moved in the cloths and slowly opened her eyes, giving hope that she would wake up to meet her brothers and sisters… but then she fell asleep effortlessly.

Catra laughed softly, adjusting her daughter in her arms and kissing her cheek. The baby had Adora's human features, but she also inherited Catra's dark hair.

— Mom, what's her name? — Finn asked.

Catra and Adora exchanged glances, smiled, and exhaled before answering.

— Mara… — said Adora, staring at the baby in the other mother's arms. — Mara Grayskull! — she exclaimed again, allowing the tears to fall once more.

Mila and Finn looked at each other, smiling, as did Isaac and Ember, before returning to gaze affectionately at the baby.

— Hey…! — Perfuma entered the room quietly.

When she saw the baby in Catra's arms, she held back from screaming with joy. Perfuma, wiping her face, held back her tears and raised a camera.

— How about a photo? — she asked, flashing a broad smile.

The family agreed, without leaving their positions, just turning their faces toward the camera and smiling broadly.

After so much suffocation and worry, the family was finally complete. And for Catra and Adora, that was indeed a happy ending.

The end.

Again.

End Notes

Hello again! So, I'm going to explain what a Druvok is.

I wanted to create some magical and dangerous animals for this fic. A Druvok is a type of bear. Except it's twice the size of a normal bear. Its fur is completely dark, and this Druvok that Adora drove away (remember it, it will be important) is especially blind in one eye and has medium-sized spikes on its back. The Druvok is terribly hungry and likes to hunt for fun. It can smell blood from 2.5 km away, and well, it may be a bit of an exaggeration on my part, but it has the ability to breathe fire. This ability is not used all the time, mainly because he doesn't need to give his size and strength. But in fights against rivals, they use this ability.

They are rarely seen, but it is not inevitable that someone will cross paths with one of them. If that happens, pray that he doesn't see you and run as far away as you can. If possible, climb a tree. Unlike bears, Druvoks cannot climb trees. So you have a chance. (But there is also a chance that it will knock the tree down to try to catch you. Sorry about that.)

Anyway, I hope you understand. If you can support me on Ko-fi, when I'm done here, I'll post all the chapters with some extras and links to the images where I got my inspiration for the animals. I'll also post the entire fic in PDF format. If you can buy me a coffee, that would be awesome too!

That's all for now. See you in the next chapter! <3

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!